THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Prelim

One step on each page: a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. The last room trains your ears.

THE ROOMS

1 · Practising well
2 · Loud and soft
3 · The staff and the keyboard
4 · Reading the notes
5 · How long is a note?
6 · Time signatures
7 · Repeats
8 · Touch: smooth and short
9 · Major scales
10 · Minor scales
11 · Chords and triads
12 · Ear training

ROOM 1 · THE STORY

Practising well

HEAR THE STORY

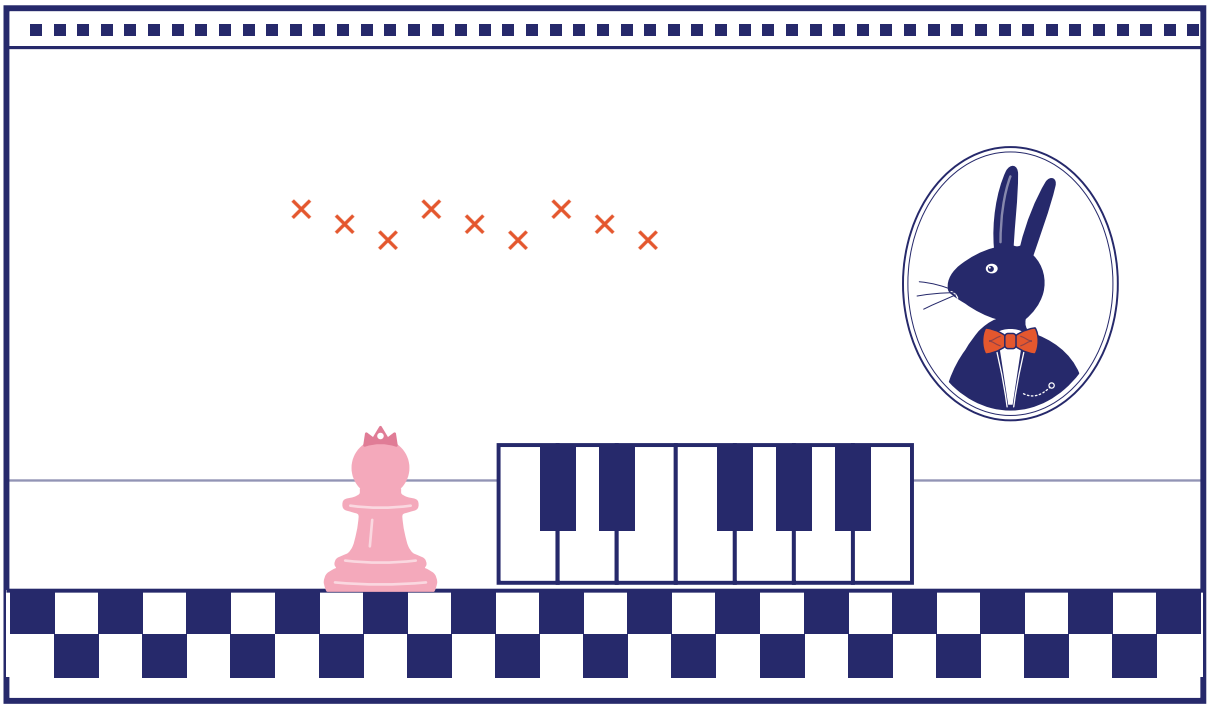
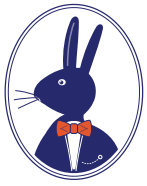


Plate I. Bar seven, the twentieth time.



Clara plays her piece from the beginning, twenty times. Each time, she stumbles in exactly the same place: bar seven.

"You have practised the mistake beautifully," says the Butler. "Twenty times."

Try it at the piano

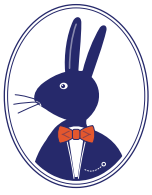
1. Find the bar in your piece that always goes wrong. Play only that bar, slowly, three times.

ROOM 1 · STEP 1 OF 3

Practising well

SCAN TO LISTEN

1	2	3
Slow	**Small**	**Correct**



Good practice is **slow**, **small** and **correct**.

Slow enough to get it right. A small piece at a time. And right from the very first try.

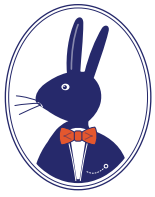
Try it at the piano

1. Choose two bars of your piece. Play them at half speed, with no wrong notes.

ROOM 1 · STEP 2 OF 3

Practising well





When it is right **three times** in a row, go **one step faster**.

If it falls apart, step back down. This is the metronome ladder.

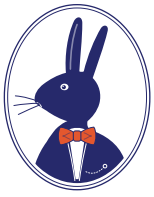
Try it at the piano

1. Set a metronome (a ticking beat-keeper; there is one in the app) to 60. Play your two bars three times. All right? Move up to 66. ○

ROOM 1 · STEP 3 OF 3

Practising well

1	2	3	4



Every piece has a **hardest bar**. Find it and practise it **first**, while your mind is fresh.

Then join it to the bar before and the bar after.

Try it at the piano

1. Find the hardest bar in your piece. Play it slowly five times, then play it with its neighbours. ○

ROOM 1 · HOW IT ENDED

Practising well

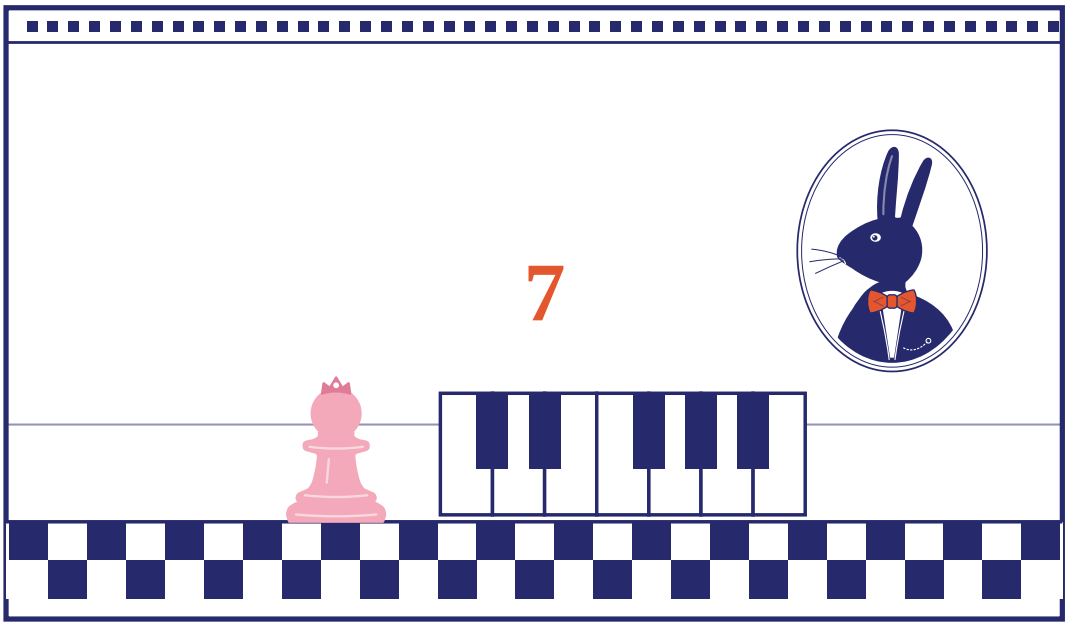


Plate I. Bar seven, slowly, alone, three times in a row.



Now Clara starts with bar seven. Slowly, alone, three times right. Then the bar before it, then the bar after.

By Thursday, nobody can tell which bar was ever the difficult one.

Try it at the piano

1. Join your difficult bar to the bars on either side. Play all three slowly, then a little faster.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

On Thursday the Butler set out two extra chairs, one at each end of the music room. "Guests," he said. "One is very quiet. The other is not."

ROOM 2 · THE STORY

Loud and soft

HEAR THE STORY

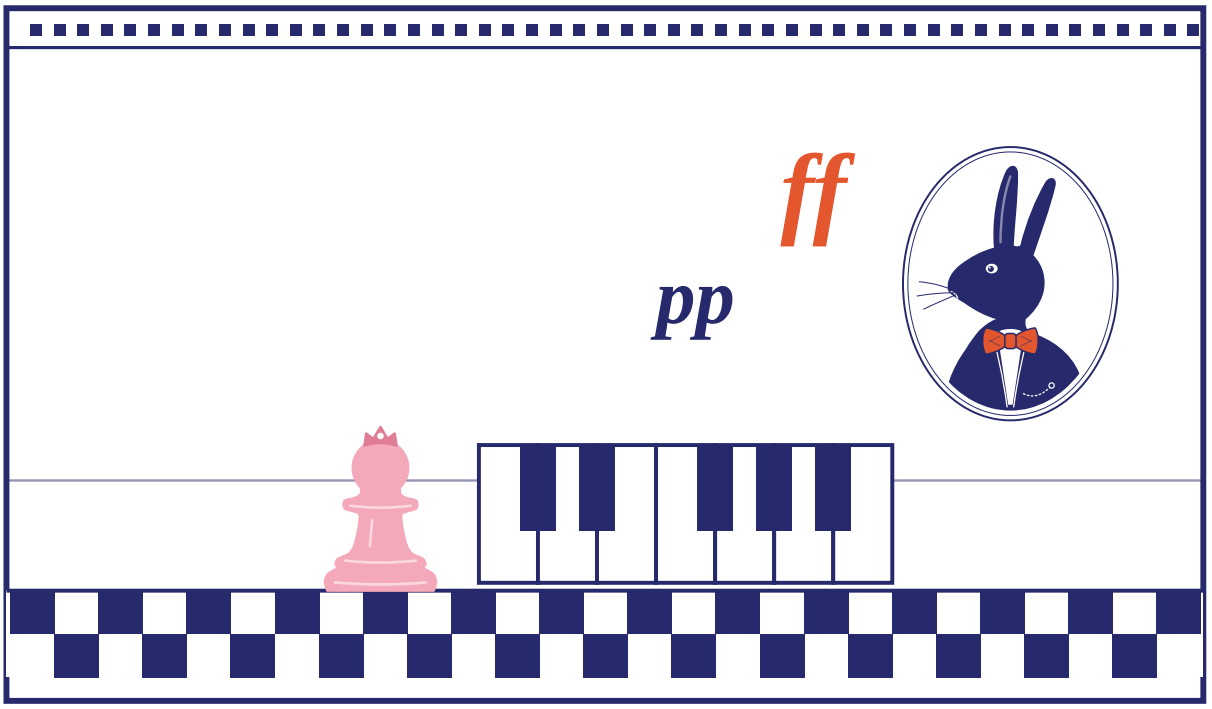
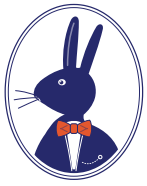


Plate II. The music evening, now with six levels.



Since last Thursday Clara has learned **soft** and **loud**. Now the Butler hands her four new signs: one softer, one louder, and two for the middle.

“A good butler has more than one way of saying no,” he says. “A good pianist has more than one way of saying loud.”

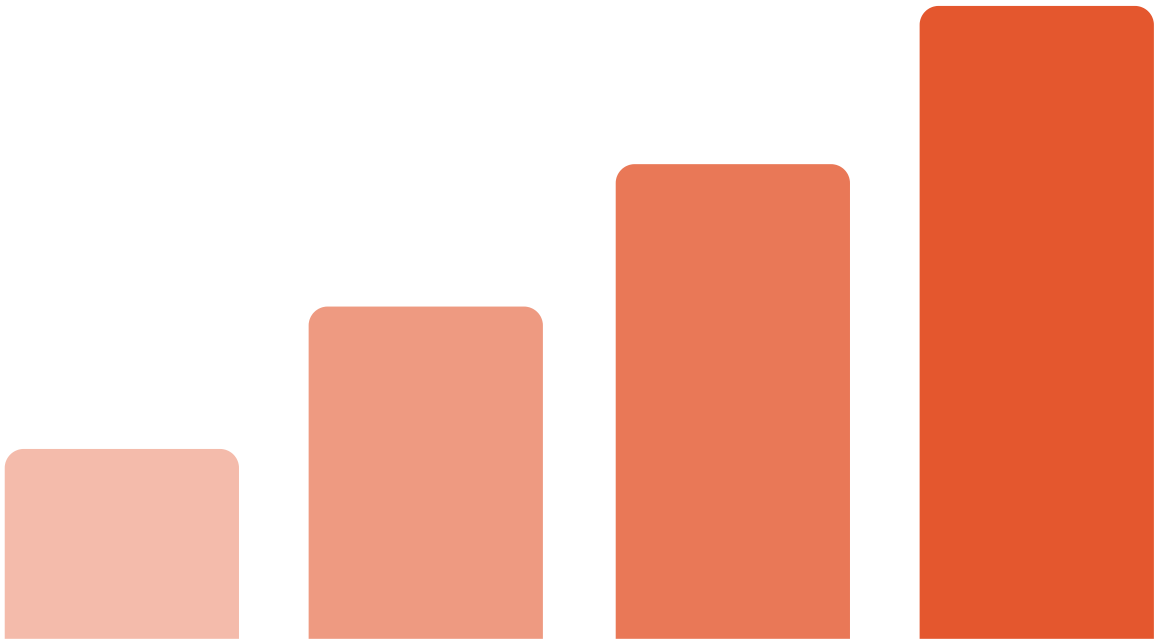
Try it at the piano

1. Play C six times, from the quietest to the loudest. Make each one a little louder than the one before.

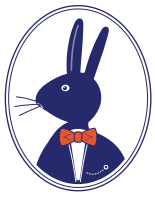
ROOM 2 · STEP 1 OF 3

Loud and soft

SCAN TO LISTEN



p	***mp***	***mf***	***f***
soft	quite soft	quite loud	loud



Four signs tell you how loud to play. ***p*** is *piano*, soft. ***f*** is *forte*, loud.

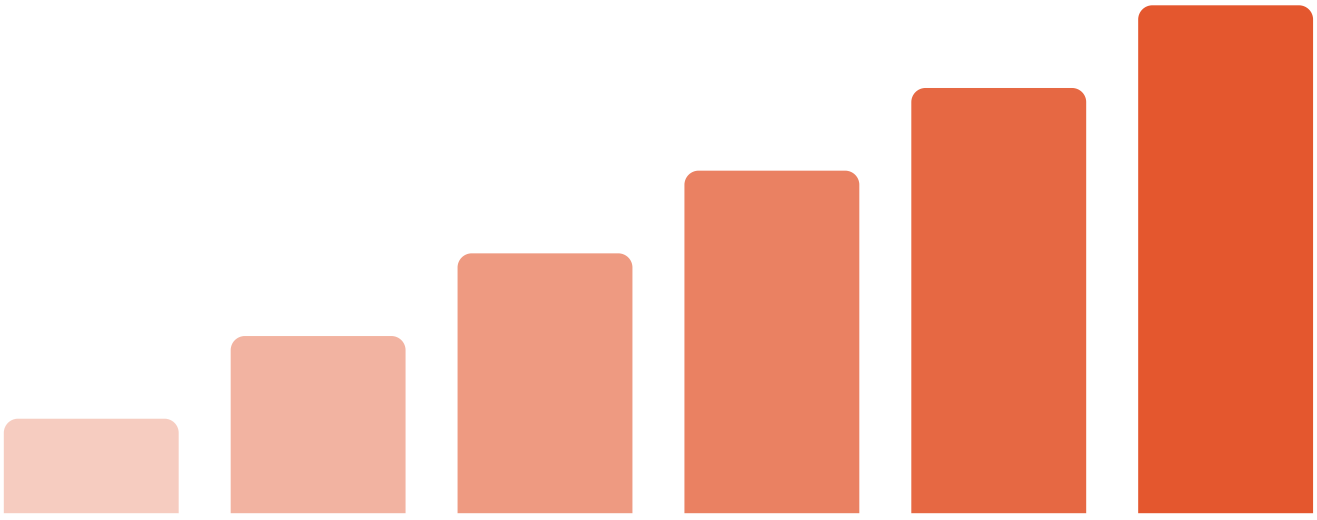
Mezzo means medium: ***mp***, mezzo piano, is quite soft and ***mf***, mezzo forte, is quite loud.

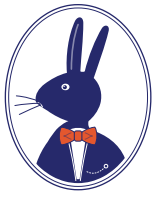
Try it at the piano

1 Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed.

ROOM 2 · STEP 2 OF 3

Loud and soft





Two letters mean **very**: ***pp*** is very soft, ***ff*** is very loud.

That makes six steps, from a whisper to a shout.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C six times, one step louder each time. Then come back down the steps.

ROOM 2 · STEP 3 OF 3

Loud and soft



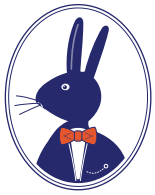
crescendo

getting louder



diminuendo

getting softer



A sign that **opens** means get louder little by little: **crescendo**. A sign that **closes** means get softer: **diminuendo**.

The wide end is the loud end.

Try it at the piano

1 Play C D E F G getting louder, then G F E D C getting softer.

ROOM 2 · HOW IT ENDED

Loud and soft



Plate II. A very quiet tune, and then one chord.



Haydn wrote a symphony in which a quiet tune goes along politely, very softly, and then one sudden chord comes crashing in.

The story goes that he wanted to wake up the audience. It has been called the *Surprise* Symphony ever since.

Try it at the piano

1. Play a tune softly, and put one loud note in somewhere. Where does the surprise work best?

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

Later, Clara found the Queen and the King arguing on the landing. Both of them were pointing at the same small note.

ROOM 3 · THE STORY

The staff and the keyboard

HEAR THE STORY

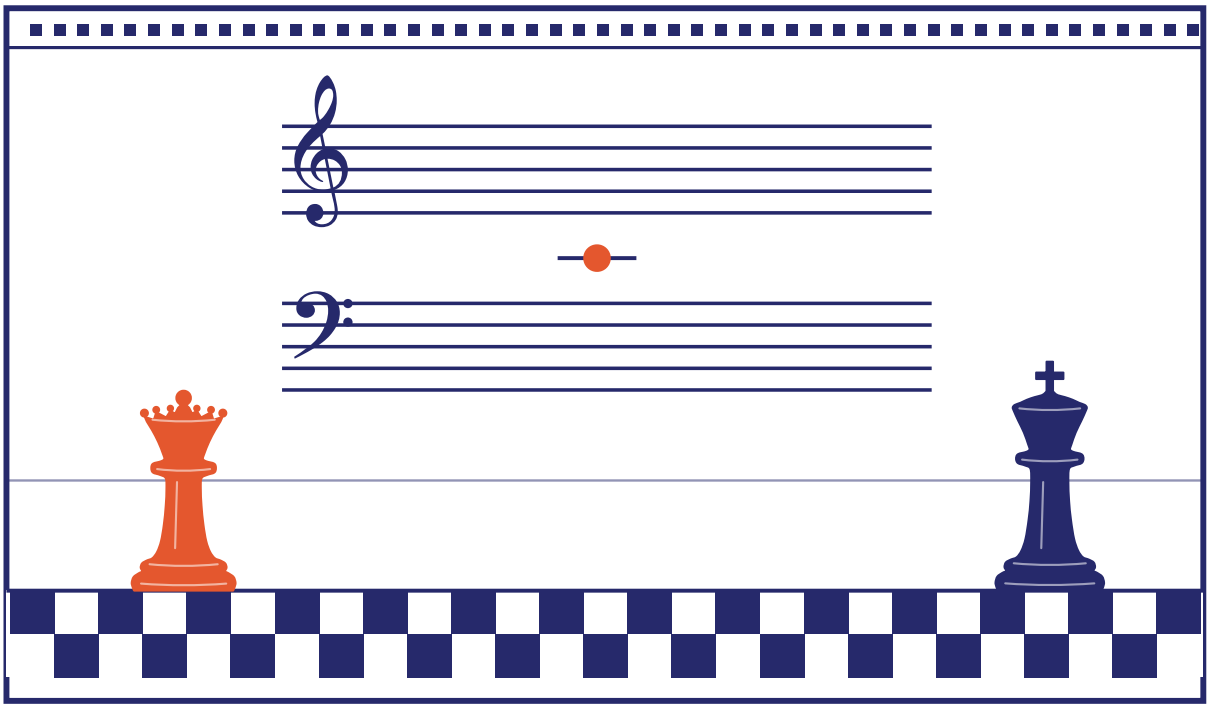
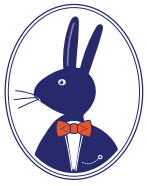


Plate III. Middle C, on the landing between two floors.



Between the Queen's floor and the King's floor there is a small **landing**. One note lives there, on a little line of its own.

Both of them claim it. It is called **Middle C**, and it belongs to both.

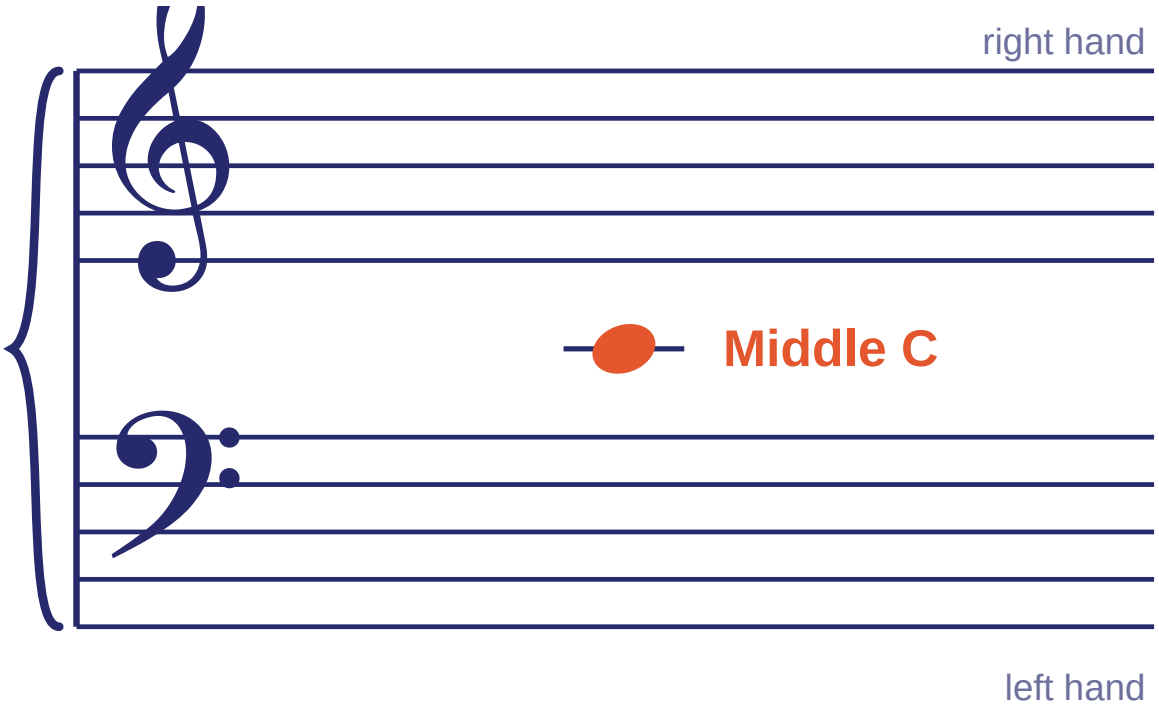
Try it at the piano

1. Find Middle C. Play it with your right thumb, then with your left thumb.

ROOM 3 · STEP 1 OF 2

The staff and the keyboard

SCAN TO LISTEN





Piano music uses **two staves** joined together: the top one for the right hand, the bottom one for the left.

The curly sign at the top is the **treble clef**. The one below is the **bass clef**.

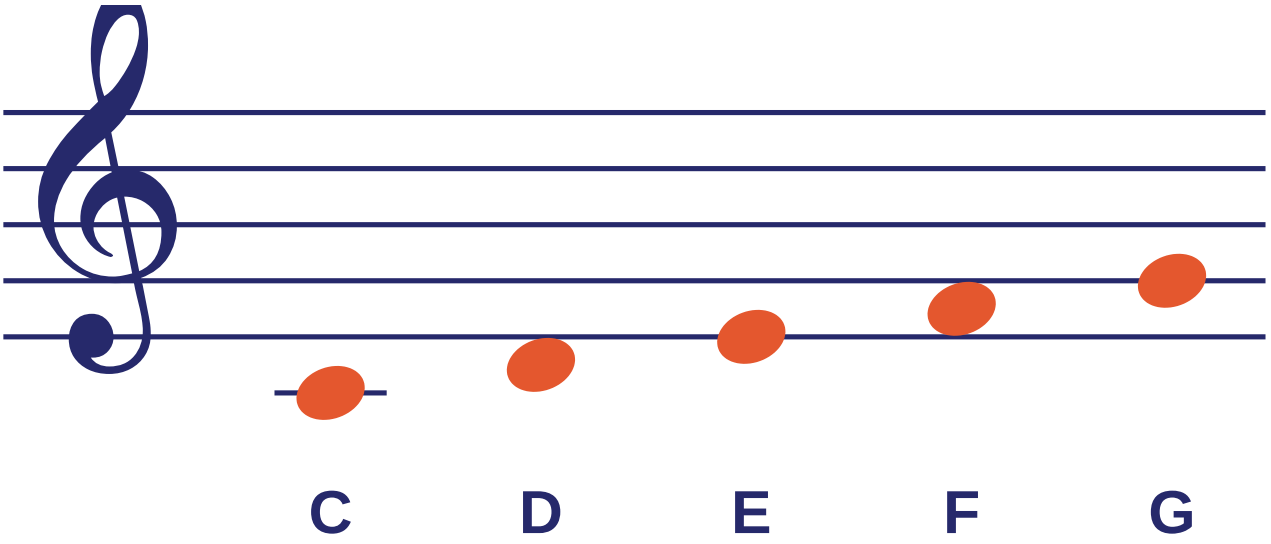
Middle C sits between them, on a little line of its own.

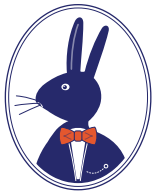
Try it at the piano

1. Find Middle C: the C nearest the middle of your piano. Play it with each thumb.

ROOM 3 · STEP 2 OF 2

The staff and the keyboard





From Middle C, each **step up** on the staff, line to space, space to line, is the **next white key** to the right.

Line, space, line, space, line: C, D, E, F, G.

Try it at the piano

1. Right thumb on Middle C. Play C D E F G while you look at the five notes on the staff. ○

ROOM 3 · HOW IT ENDED

The staff and the keyboard

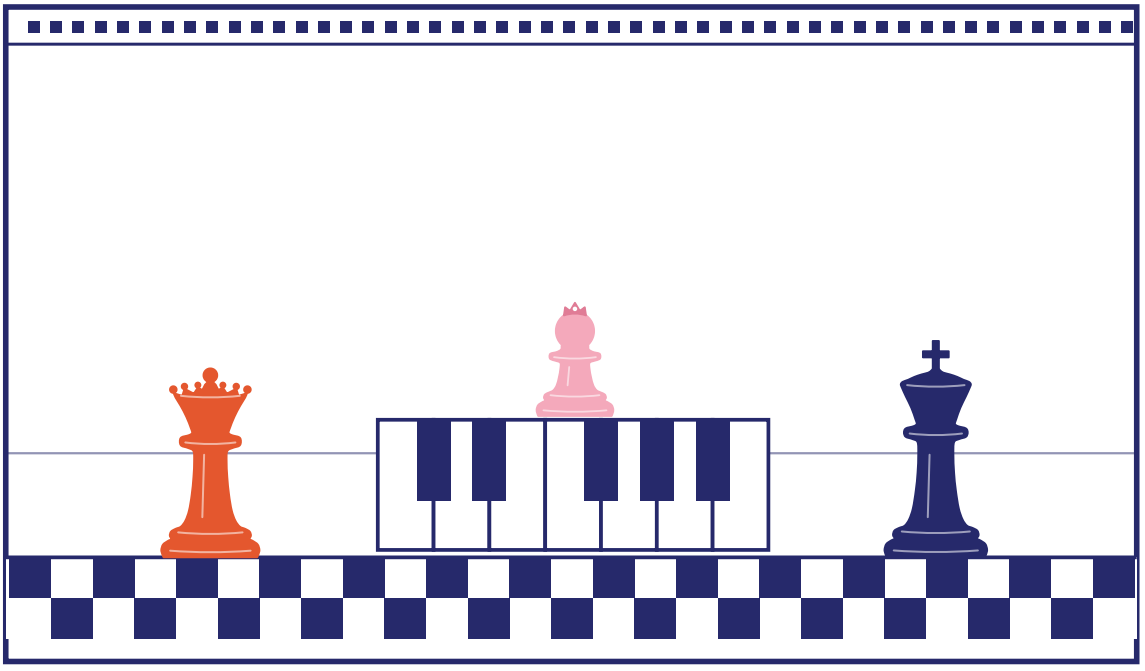


Plate III. The Queen and the King, agreeing for once.



In the end the Queen and the King agree. Middle C will be shared, and whoever needs it may use it.

It is the only thing in the house they have ever agreed on.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C D E F G with your right hand from Middle C, then C B A G F with your left. Both start on the same key.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

The Queen announced that anyone who wished to read her floor must first learn her sentence. The King said he had one too, and that his was better.

ROOM 4 · THE STORY

Reading the notes

HEAR THE STORY

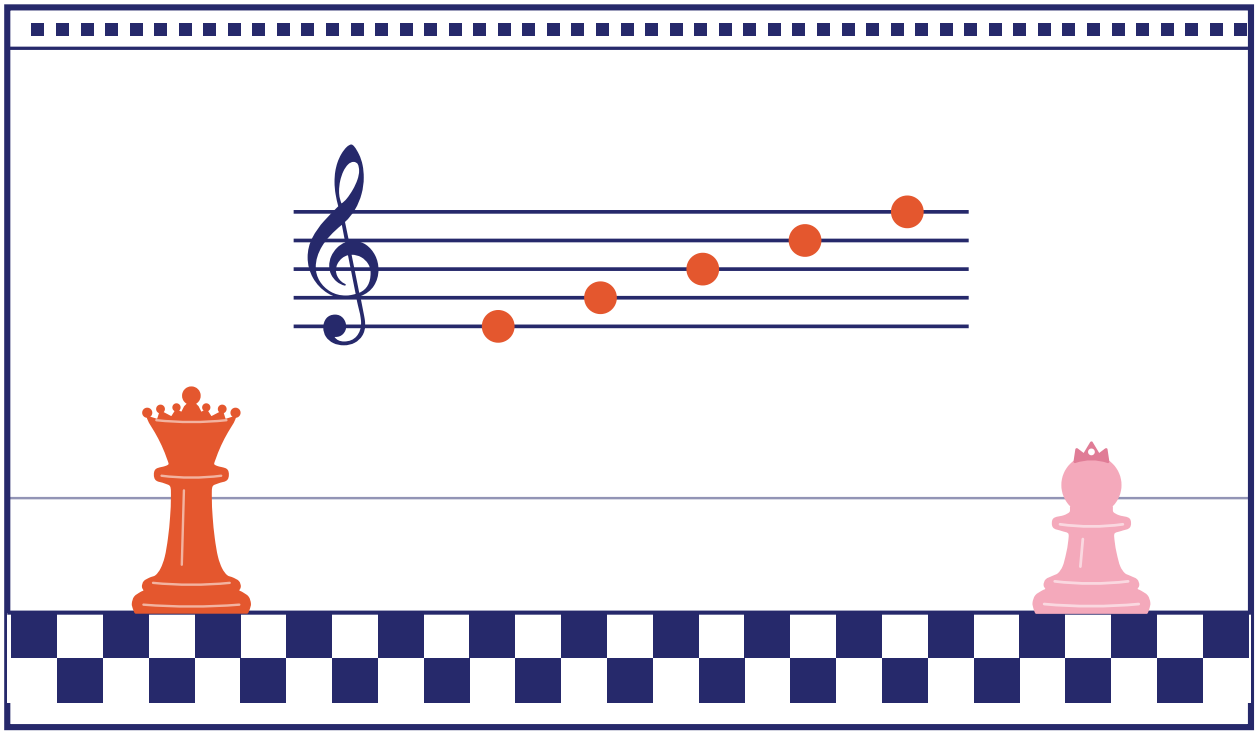
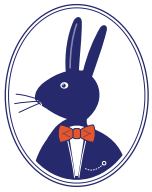


Plate IV. The Queen's sentence, written on her five lines.



The Queen has a sentence for her five lines, and she expects everyone to know it: **E**very **G**ood **B**oy **D**eserves **F**un.

Clara suspects the Queen made it up herself.

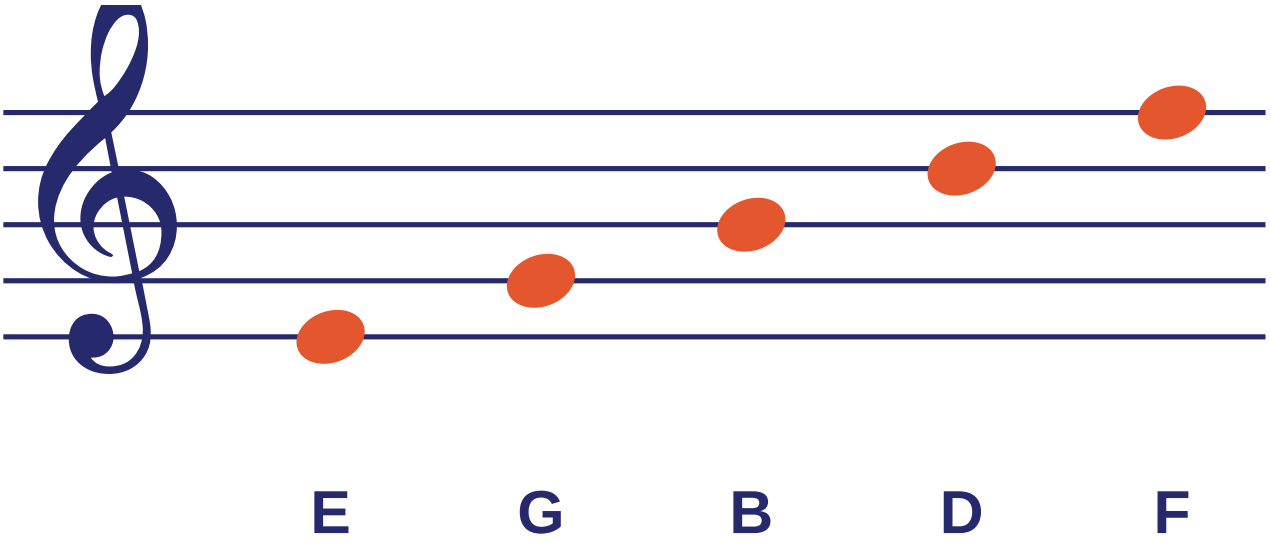
Try it

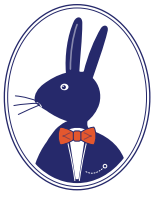
1 Say the Queen's sentence and point to the five lines of the treble staff, from the bottom up.

ROOM 4 · STEP 1 OF 3

Reading the notes

SCAN TO LISTEN





The five **lines** of the treble staff are **E G B D F**, from the bottom up.

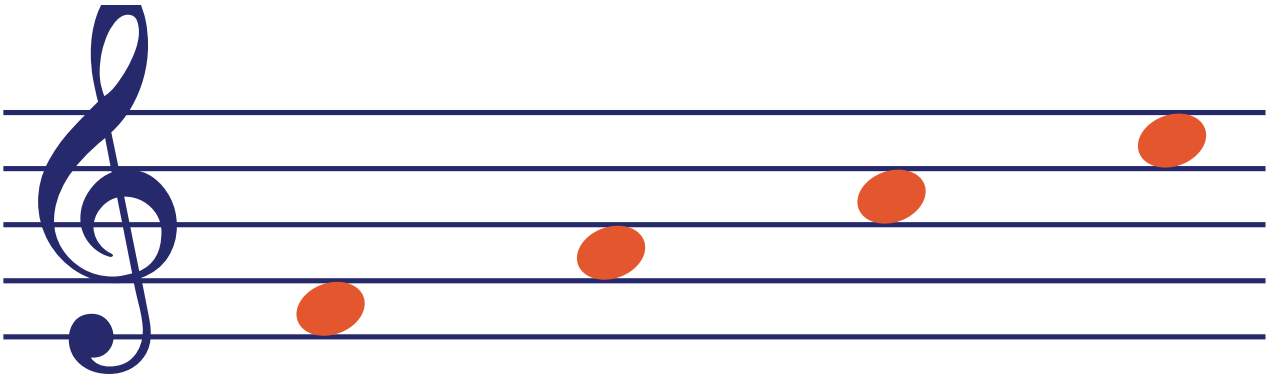
A sentence helps: **E**very **G**ood **B**oy **D**eserves **F**un.

Try it at the piano

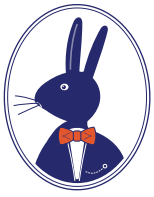
1. Play E G B D F going up from the E above Middle C, saying the sentence.

ROOM 4 · STEP 2 OF 3

Reading the notes



F A C E



The four **spaces** of the treble staff spell a word: **F A C E**.

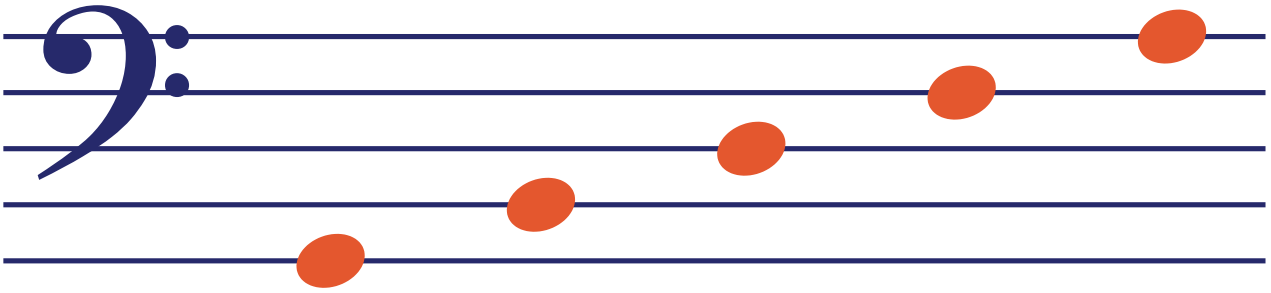
Lines and spaces take turns, so the notes go F, G, A, B, C, D, E.

Try it at the piano

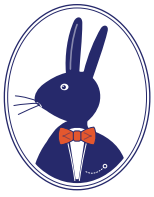
1. Play F A C E going up. Then play F G A and say which is a space and which is a line.

ROOM 4 · STEP 3 OF 3

Reading the notes



G B D F A



The bass staff has its own names. Its **lines** are **G B D F A**: **G**reat **B**ig **D**ragons **F**ly **A**way.

Its spaces are **A C E G**: **A**ll **C**ows **E**at **G**rass.

Try it at the piano

1. With your left hand, play G B D F A going up from the second G below Middle C, saying the sentence.

ROOM 4 · HOW IT ENDED

Reading the notes

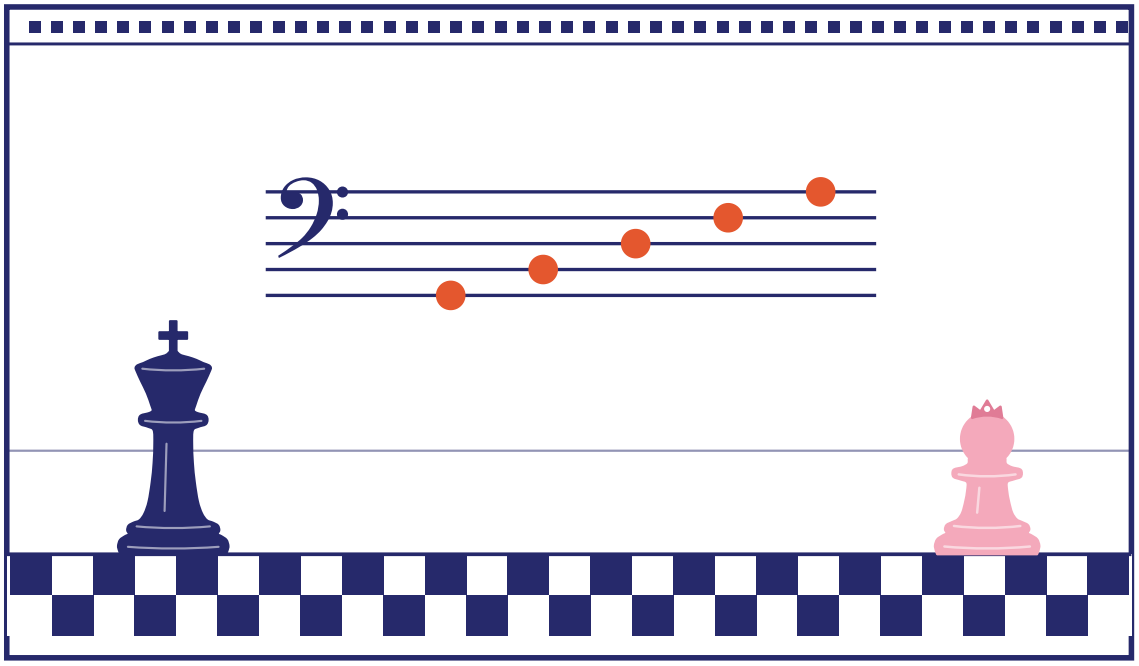
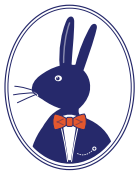


Plate IV. The King's sentence, which involves dragons.



Not to be outdone, the King has a sentence of his own: **G**reat **B**ig **D**ragons **F**ly **A**way.

Clara now knows both. She has decided not to ask which of them came first.

Try it

1. Say the King's sentence and point to the five lines of the bass staff. Then make up your own sentence.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

At tea the Butler brought in one round cake and a very sharp knife. "Today," he said, "we learn to count it."

ROOM 5 · THE STORY

How long is a note?

HEAR THE STORY

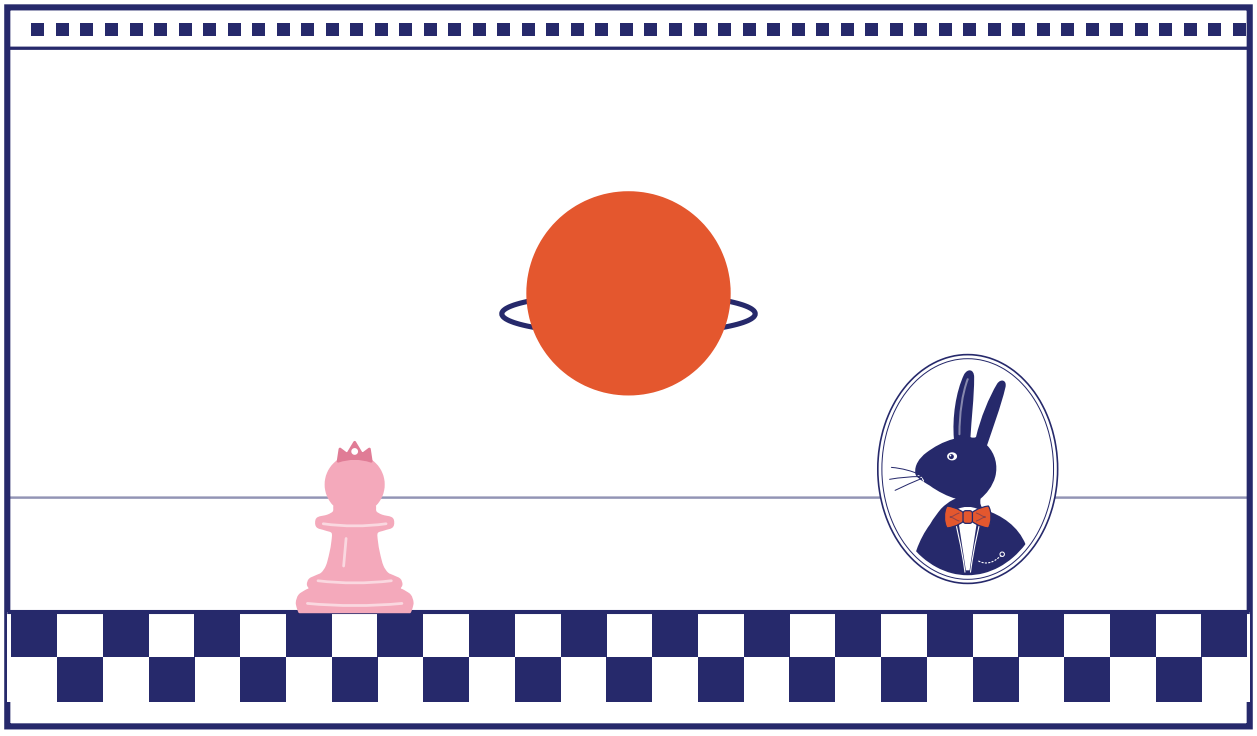
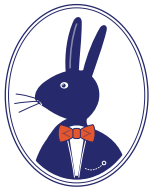


Plate V. Tea is served. There is one cake.



At tea there is one round cake, and the Butler has a knife. One cake is **one beat**.

“Cut it in two,” he says, “and you have two halves of a beat. Cut it in four…” Clara sees where this is going.

Try it

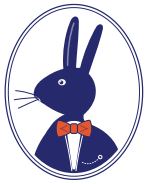
1 Clap four slow beats. Then clap twice on every beat. Then four times. Keep the beat the same.

ROOM 5 · STEP 1 OF 7

How long is a note?

SCAN TO LISTEN





One circle is **one beat**. A **crotchet** is one circle. A **minim** is two, a **dotted minim** three and a **semibreve** four.

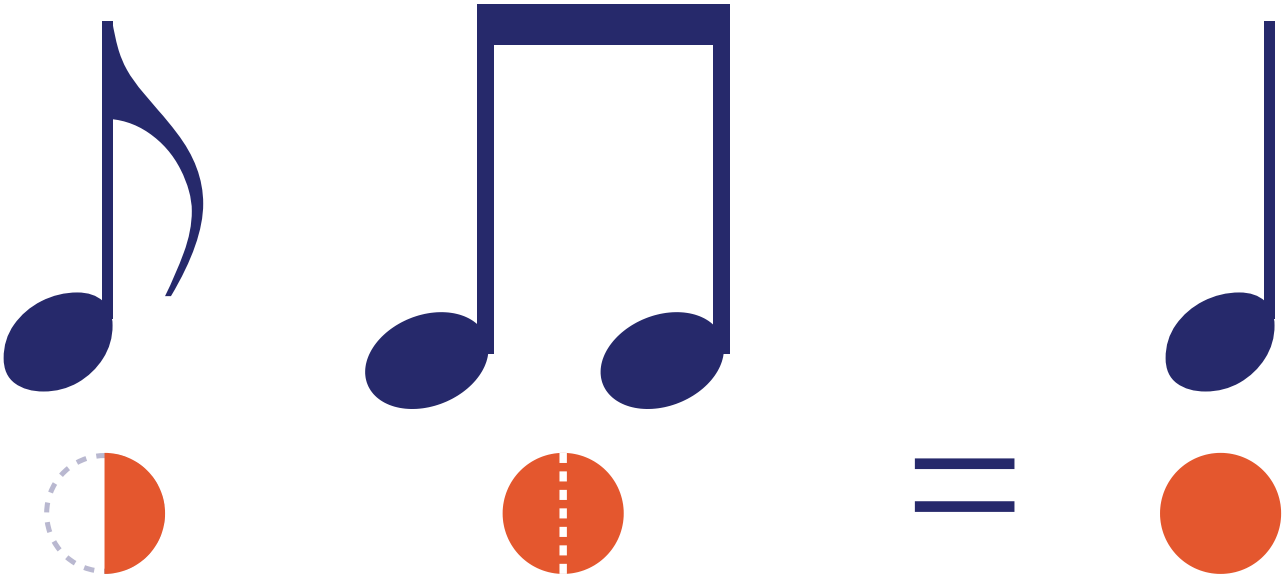
Now come the notes shorter than one beat: pieces of the circle.

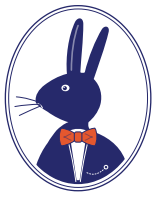
Try it at the piano

1 Play C as a semibreve, a dotted minim, a minim and a crotchet, counting the beats out loud: 1 2 3 4.

ROOM 5 · STEP 2 OF 7

How long is a note?





Cut the circle in half. A **quaver** is **half a beat**, and on its own it has a **tail**.

Put two halves together and you have one whole beat: two quavers joined by a **beam**. We count them **1 and**.

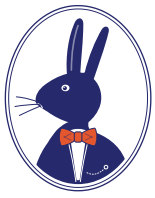
Try it at the piano

1 Play C in crotchets, counting 1 2 3 4. Then in quavers, counting 1 and 2 and 3 and 4 and.

ROOM 5 · STEP 3 OF 7

How long is a note?





Cut the circle in four. A **semiquaver** is a **quarter of a beat**, and on its own it has **two tails**.

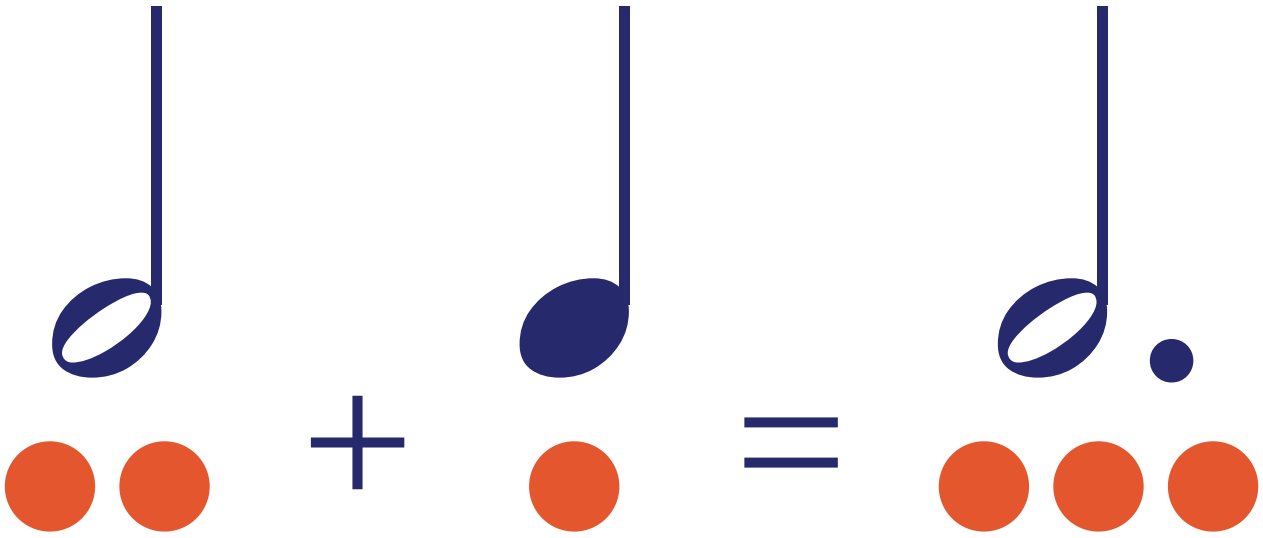
Put four quarters together and you have one whole beat: four semiquavers joined by **two beams**. Say **wa-ter-me-lon**.

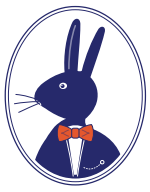
Try it

1 Clap four beats. Then tap four semiquavers on every beat, saying wa-ter-me-lon.

ROOM 5 · STEP 4 OF 7

How long is a note?





A **dot after a note** makes it longer: it adds **half** of the note again. That is why a dotted minim has one more beat.

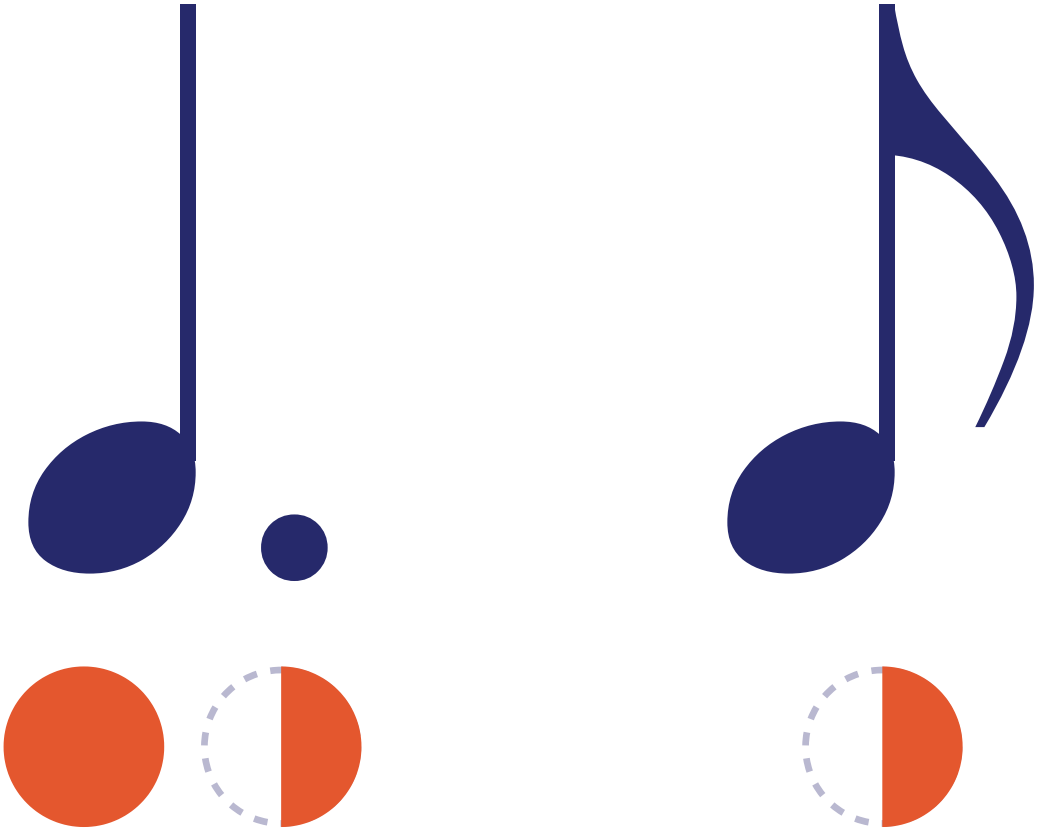
A minim is 2 beats. Half of 2 is 1. So a dotted minim is 2 + 1 = **3 beats**.

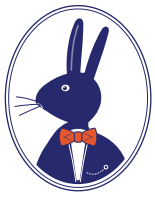
Try it at the piano

1 Play C as a minim, counting 1 2. Then as a dotted minim, counting 1 2 3.

ROOM 5 · STEP 5 OF 7

How long is a note?





A dot after a crotchet adds half a beat: a **dotted crotchet** is **one beat and a half**.

A quaver usually follows it to finish the second beat. Long, then short: **1 – 2 and**.

Try it at the piano

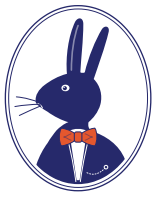
1. Play C long, then D short, counting 1 – 2 and. The D comes on the “and”.

ROOM 5 · STEP 6 OF 7

How long is a note?



2 + 1 = 3 beats



A **tie** is a curved line joining two notes that are the **same**. Play the first one and **hold** through the second.

A minim tied to a crotchet lasts three beats.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C and hold it for 1 2 3. You have played two notes with one press.

ROOM 5 · STEP 7 OF 7

How long is a note?



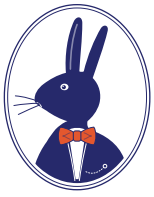
1 beat



2 beats



4 beats



A **rest** is a sign for **silence**. You count it just like a note, but you do not play.

The crotchet rest lasts 1 beat. The minim rest sits on a line for 2. The semibreve rest hangs under a line for 4.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C, C, then lift your hand for one beat, then C: 1, 2, (rest), 4. Keep counting through the silence.

ROOM 5 · HOW IT ENDED

How long is a note?

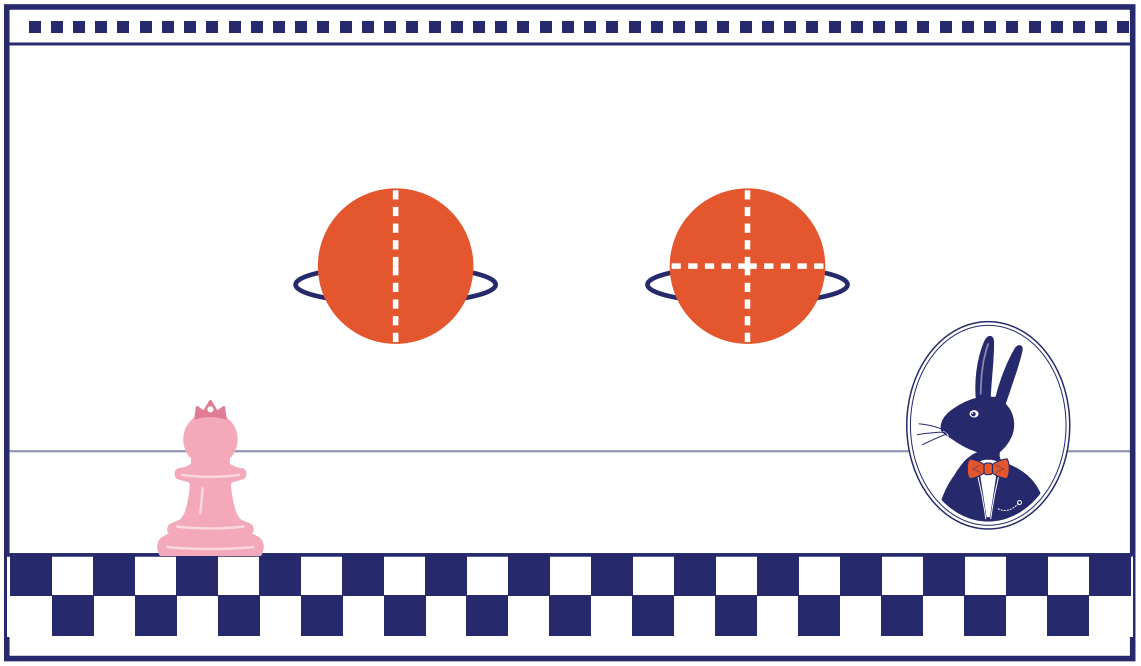
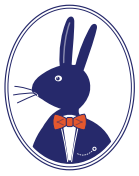


Plate V. Two halves, four quarters, still one cake.



Two halves or four quarters: it is still the same cake, and still the **same beat**. Only the slices change.

Clara notices the Butler took a quarter. Nobody says anything.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C in crotchets, then quavers, then semiquavers, while someone taps a steady beat. ○

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

Then a whistle blew at the bottom of the garden. Clara had not known the house had a station.

ROOM 6 · THE STORY

Time signatures

HEAR THE STORY

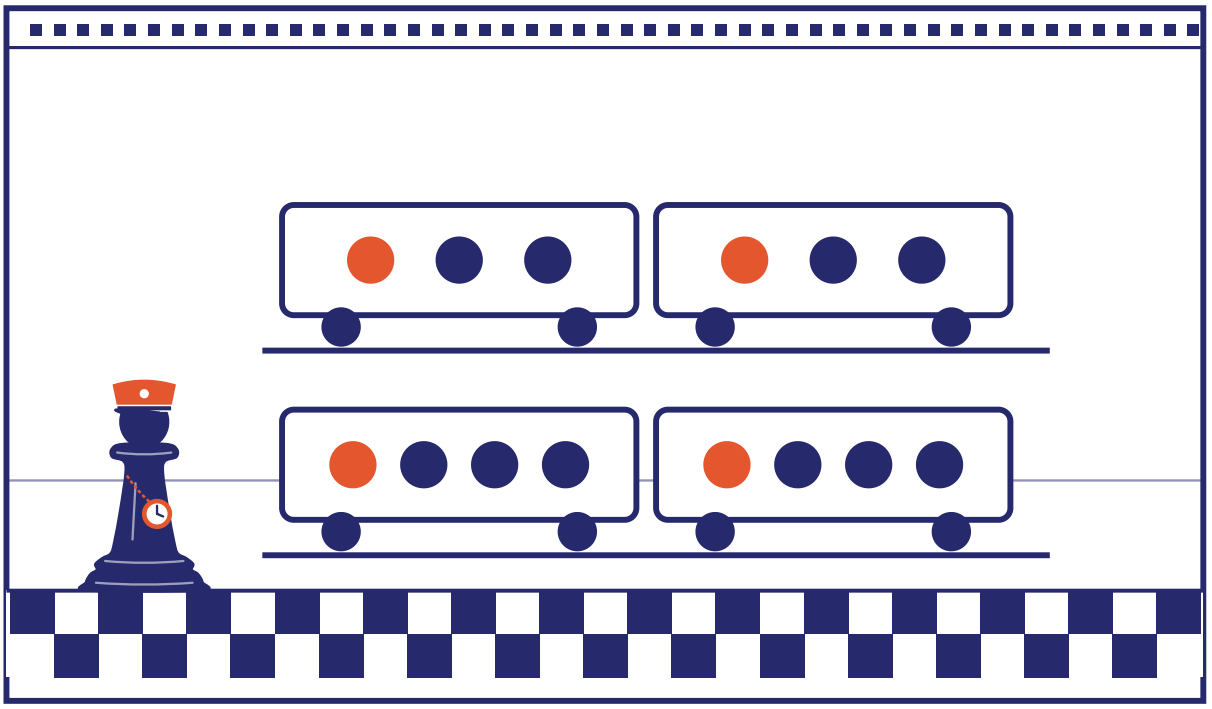
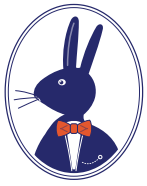


Plate VI. Two trains: three seats to a carriage, and four.



At the end of the garden is a small station, and the **Stationmaster** is very strict. Every carriage must have the same number of seats.

Before a piece begins he shows two numbers. The top one says how many seats are in each carriage.

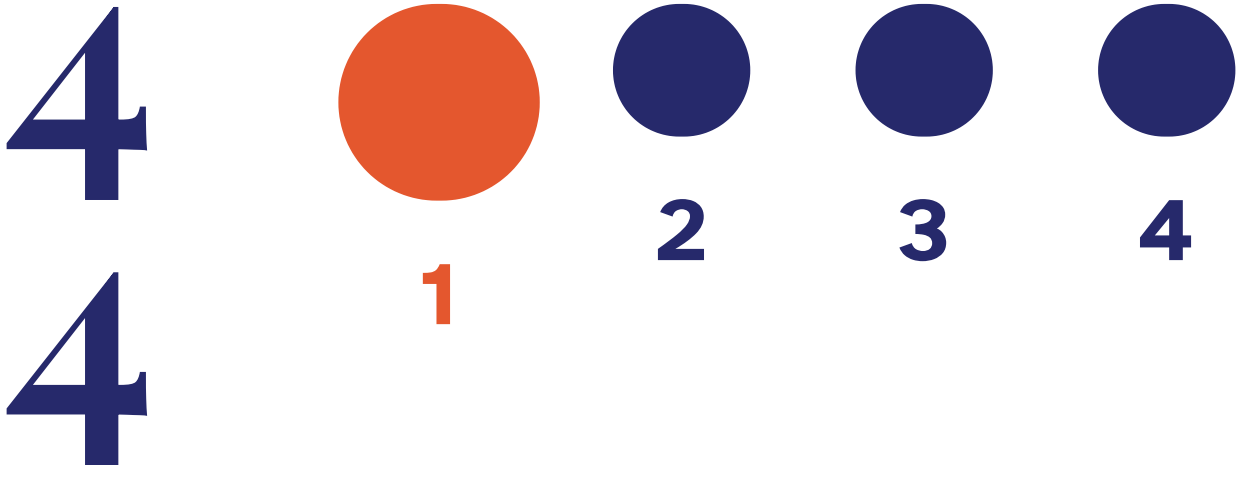
Try it

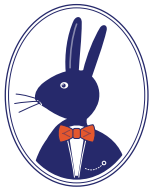
1. Clap three seats in each carriage: ONE two three, ONE two three. Then four.

ROOM 6 · STEP 1 OF 3

Time signatures

SCAN TO LISTEN





The two numbers at the start are the **time signature**.

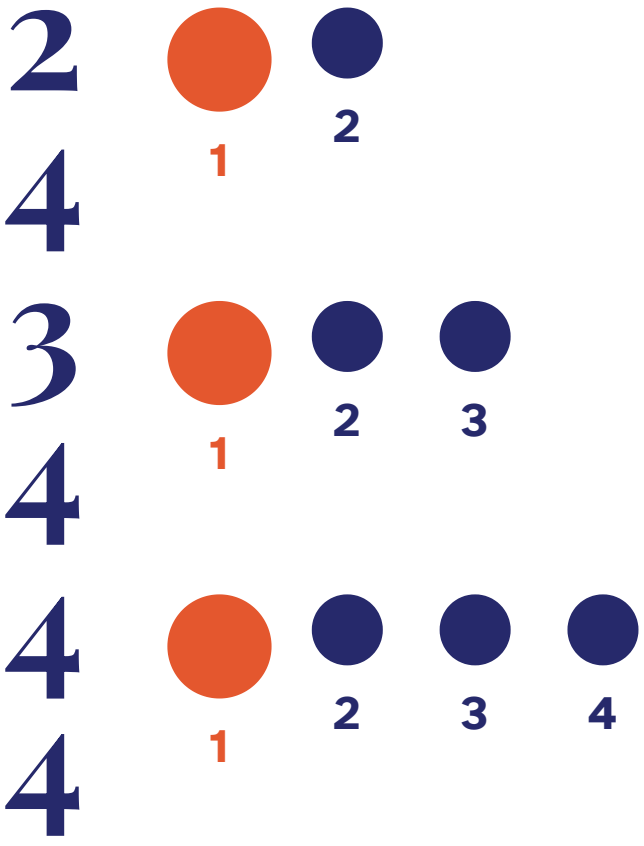
The **top number** says how many beats are in every bar. The bottom 4 says each beat is a crotchet.

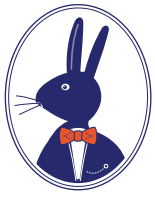
Try it

1. Clap four beats in a bar, the first one stronger: ONE two three four.

ROOM 6 · STEP 2 OF 3

Time signatures





Two in a bar marches: left, right. **Three** in a bar swings round, like a waltz. **Four** in a bar walks along: 1 2 3 4.

Beat 1 is always the strongest.

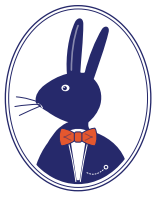
Try it

1. Clap each one: ONE two · ONE two three · ONE two three four. Which does your piece use?

ROOM 6 · STEP 3 OF 3

Time signatures

1	2	3
Andante	**Moderato**	**Allegro**
at a walk	not slow, not fast	quick and lively



A word above the first bar tells you **how fast** the beat goes. The words are Italian.

Andante is a walking speed. **Moderato** is in the middle. **Allegro** is quick and lively.

Try it

1. Clap four beats Andante, then Moderato, then Allegro. Find the speed word at the top of your piece.

ROOM 6 · HOW IT ENDED

Time signatures

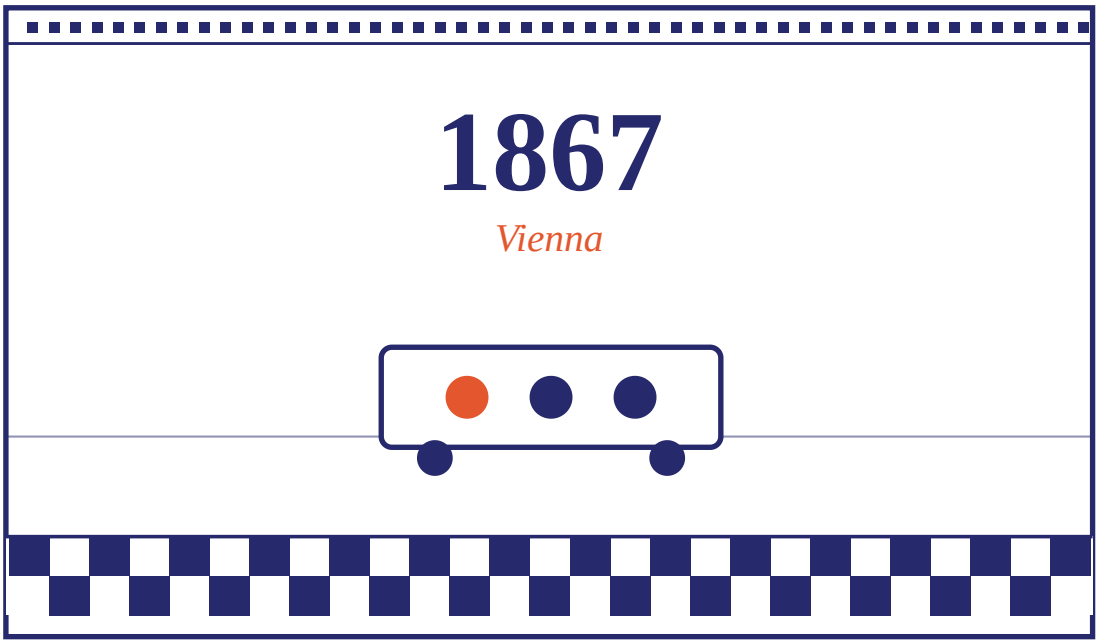


Plate VI. Three seats to a carriage, all the way down the Danube.



In Vienna, **Johann Strauss II** wrote waltzes with three beats in every bar. The most famous is *The Blue Danube*, first heard in 1867.

Before long the whole world was dancing to it: one two three, one two three. The Stationmaster, for once, had no complaints.

Try it at the piano

1. Play or hum a waltz and sway on beat 1: ONE two three. Then march a two: LEFT right.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

Walking back from the station, Clara took the long corridor. She turned one corner, then another, and found the same door. Again.

ROOM 7 · THE STORY

Repeats

HEAR THE STORY

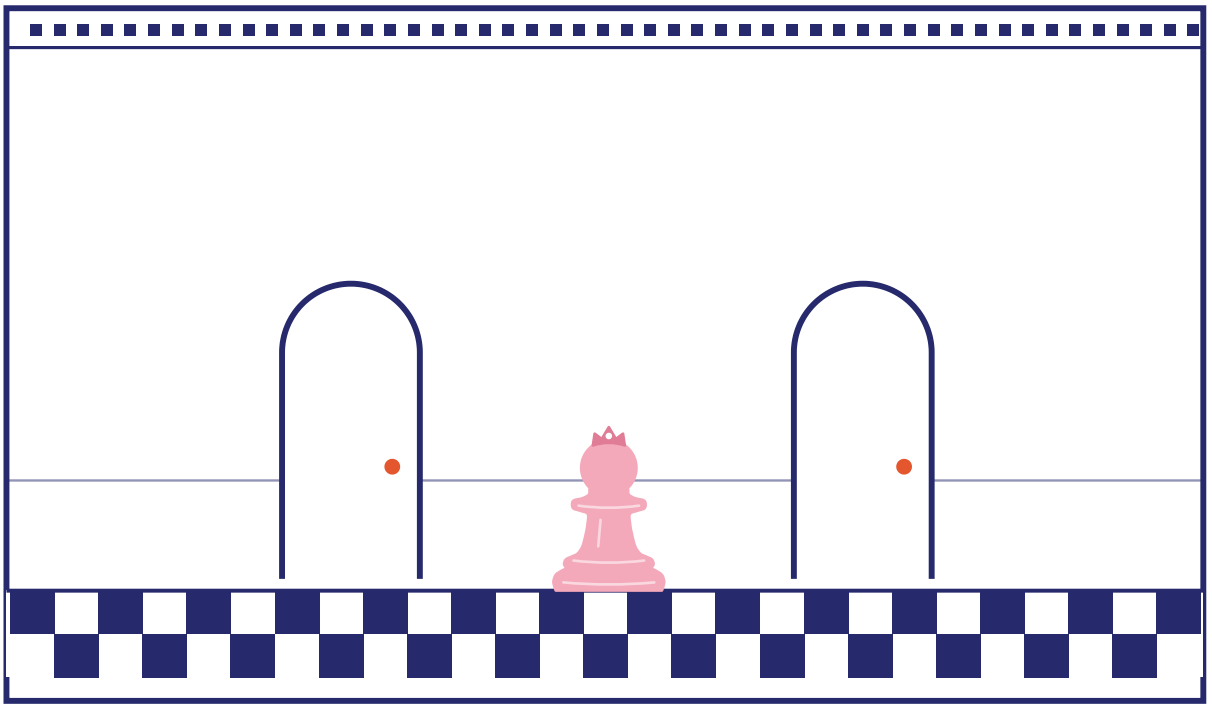
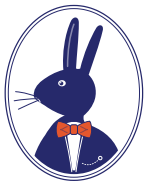


Plate VII. The same door, again.



Clara walks down a corridor, turns a corner and finds herself at the **same door** as before. She is quite sure she did not turn round.

"That," says the Butler, "is a repeat sign. It is supposed to happen."

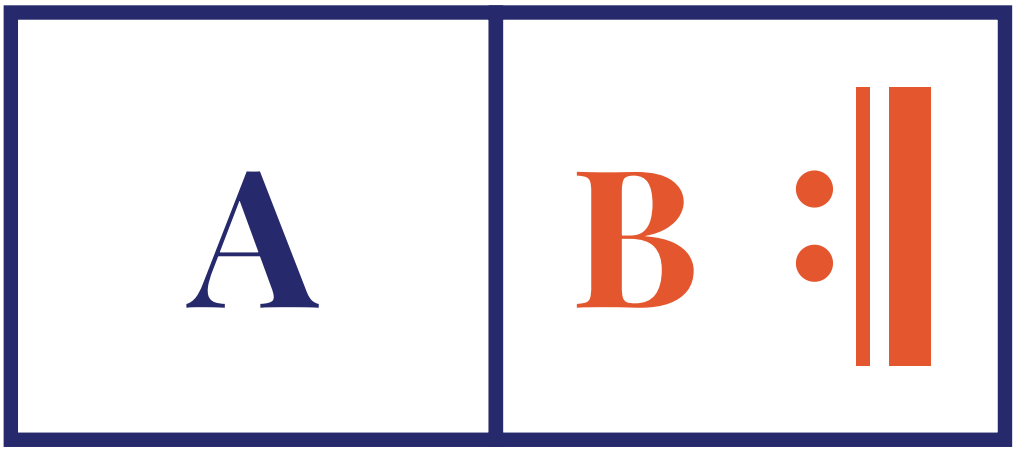
Try it at the piano

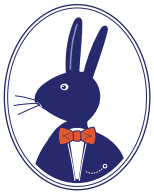
1. Play a short tune twice, without stopping in between. Did it feel like the same door?

ROOM 7 · STEP 1 OF 2

Repeats

SCAN TO LISTEN





Two dots beside a double bar line make a **repeat sign**. It means: **go back and play it again**.

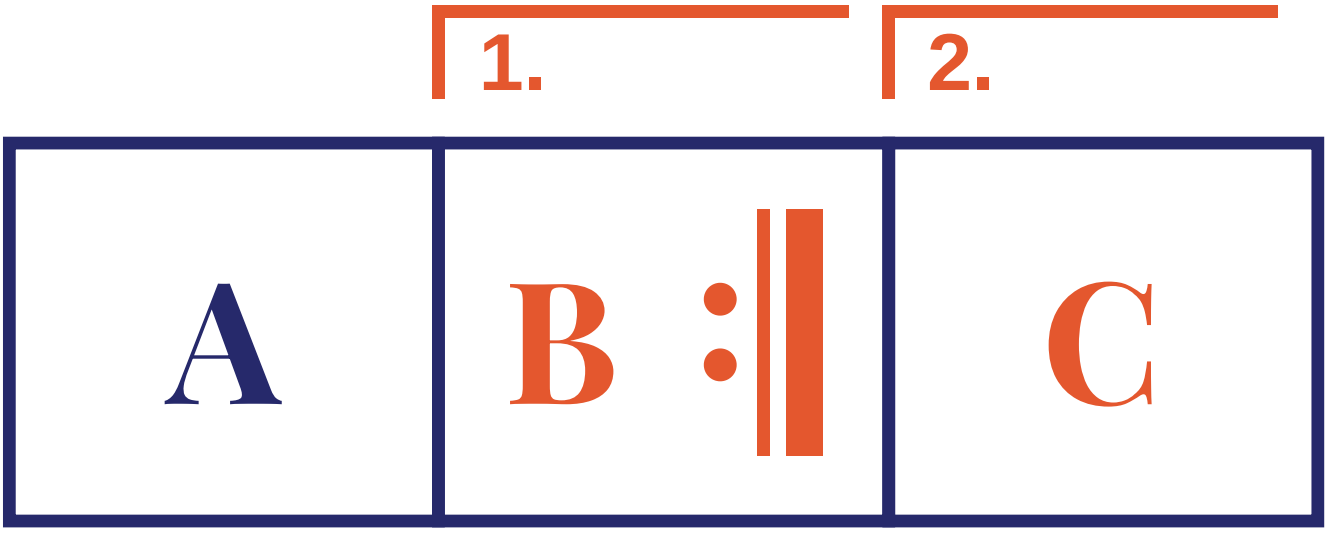
So this music is played A B, then A B once more.

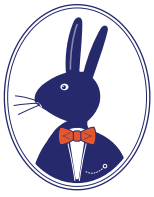
Try it at the piano

1 Find a repeat sign in your book. Play up to it, then go back to the start and play it again.

ROOM 7 · STEP 2 OF 2

Repeats





A repeat can have two endings. The bar marked **1** is played the first time only.

The second time, **skip it** and jump to the bar marked **2**: A B, then A C.

Try it

1. Say the order out loud for this picture: A, B, back, A, C. Then look for a first-time bar in your music.

ROOM 7 · HOW IT ENDED

Repeats

1781

Vienna

★ ★ ★

Plate VII. One small tune, twelve different doors.



Mozart took a little French tune, the one you know as *Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star*, and played it again and again, each time a little different.

He wrote twelve variations on it. The tune comes back each time, but never through quite the same door.

Try it at the piano

1. Play the start of Twinkle, Twinkle. Then play it again, one change: louder, shorter, or higher.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

In the kitchen the Butler was pouring tea. Clara noticed he poured it in two different ways, and never once mixed them up.

ROOM 8 · THE STORY

Touch: smooth and short

HEAR THE STORY

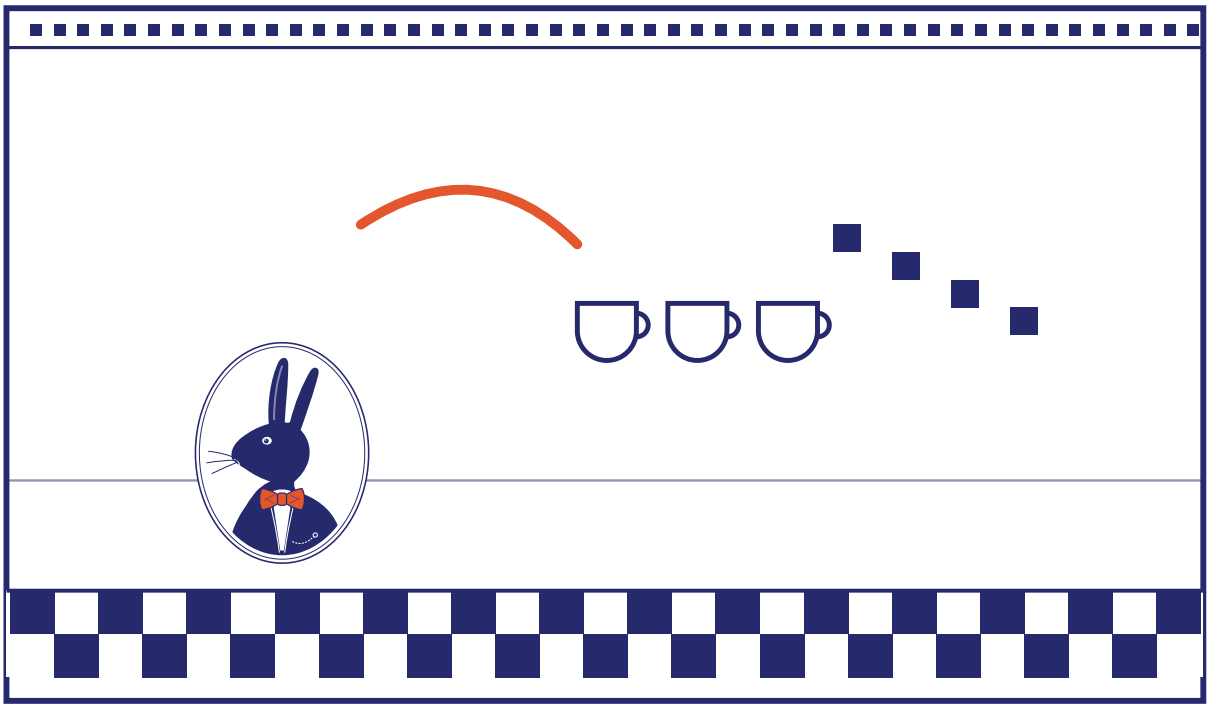
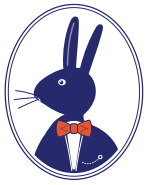


Plate VIII. Tea poured in one stream; sugar dropped one lump at a time.



The Butler pours the tea in one **smooth** stream, from the first cup to the last, without a drip in between.

Then he drops in the sugar: one lump, two lumps, three. **Short**, and separate, and very precise.

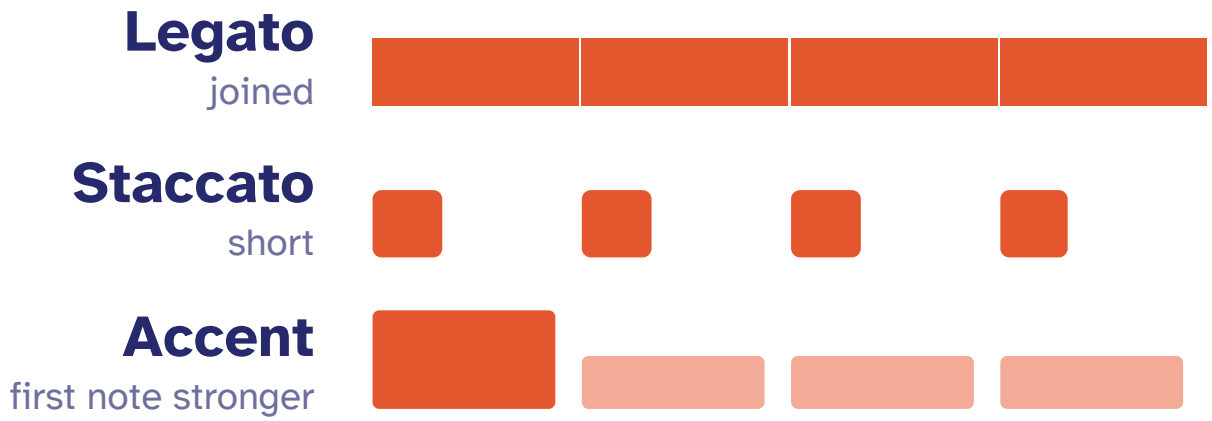
Try it at the piano

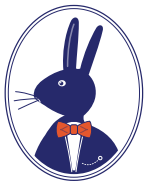
1 Play five notes like the tea, smooth and joined. Then like the sugar, short and separate.

ROOM 8 · STEP 1 OF 2

Touch: smooth and short

SCAN TO LISTEN





The same notes can be played in different ways. **Legato** means smooth and joined. **Staccato**, a dot above or below the note head, means short.

An **accent** (>) means that note is stronger. Remember: a dot *after* a note makes it longer, a dot *under* it makes it short.

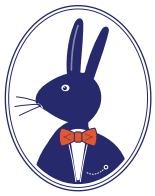
Try it at the piano

1 Play C D E F G smoothly, each finger passing the sound to the next. Then play it staccato, like hot keys.

ROOM 8 · STEP 2 OF 2

Touch: smooth and short





A curved line over **different** notes is a **slur**. Play them smoothly, in one breath, and lift gently at the end.

A tie joins the same note; a slur joins different ones.

Try it at the piano

1 Play C D E F as one slur: sink into the C, float off the F.

ROOM 8 · HOW IT ENDED

Touch: smooth and short

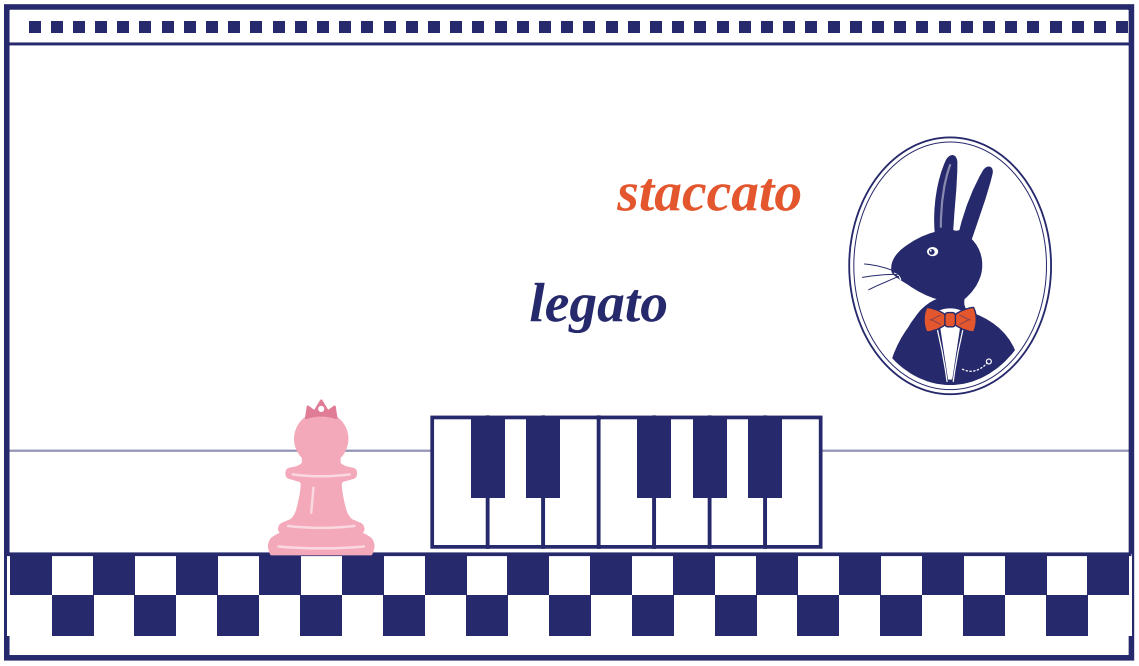
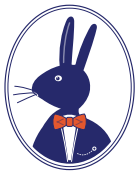


Plate VIII. Tea and sugar, both at the piano.



Now Clara has names for both. Tea is **legato**. Sugar is **staccato**.

She finds that her pieces use both, often in the same line. The Butler, for the record, takes two lumps.

Try it at the piano

1. Find a place in your piece that is legato and a place that is staccato. Play each one the way the Butler would serve it.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

That evening the doorbell rang. On the step stood a Guest in a tall hat, and on the hat was a sign Clara had never seen.

ROOM 9 · THE STORY

Major scales

HEAR THE STORY

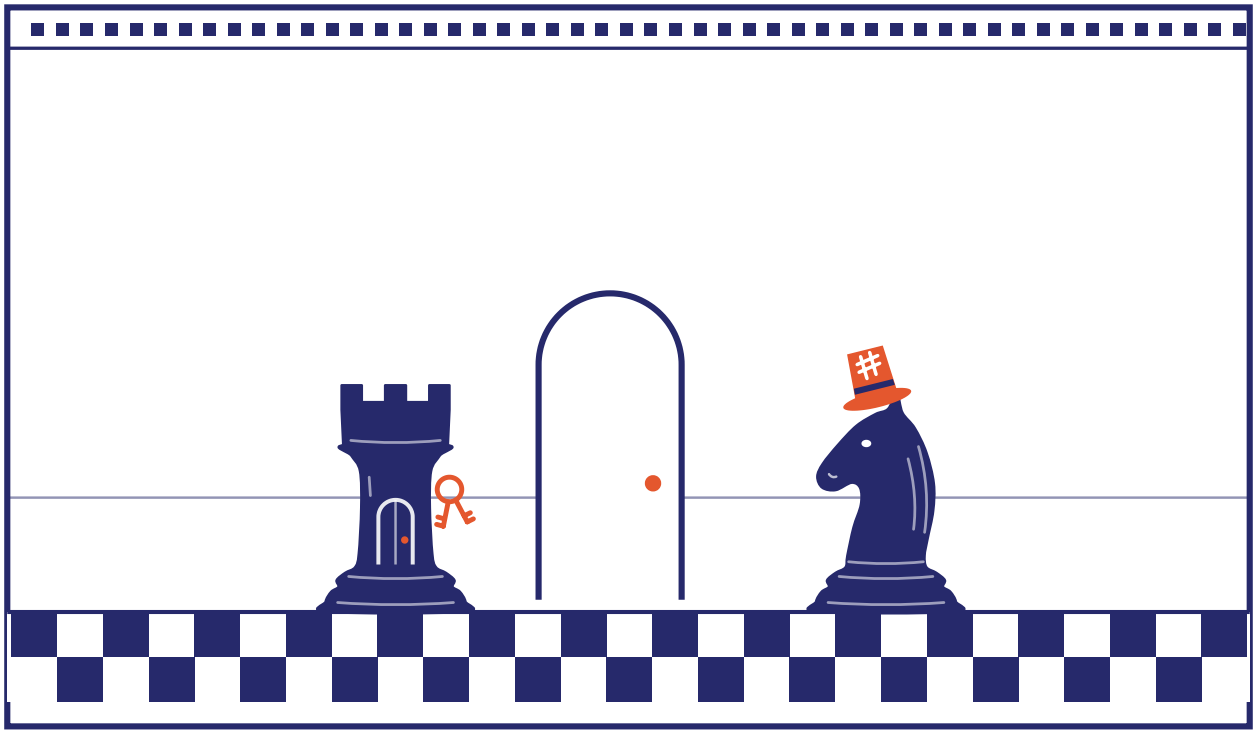
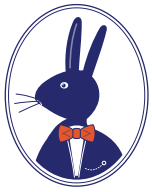


Plate IX. The Guest arrives in a hat with a sharp on it.



A **Guest** arrives at the door wearing a hat with a **sharp** on it. He wishes to visit G major.

The **Doorkeeper** looks at his list. “In G major,” he says, “every F wears that hat. All the way through.”

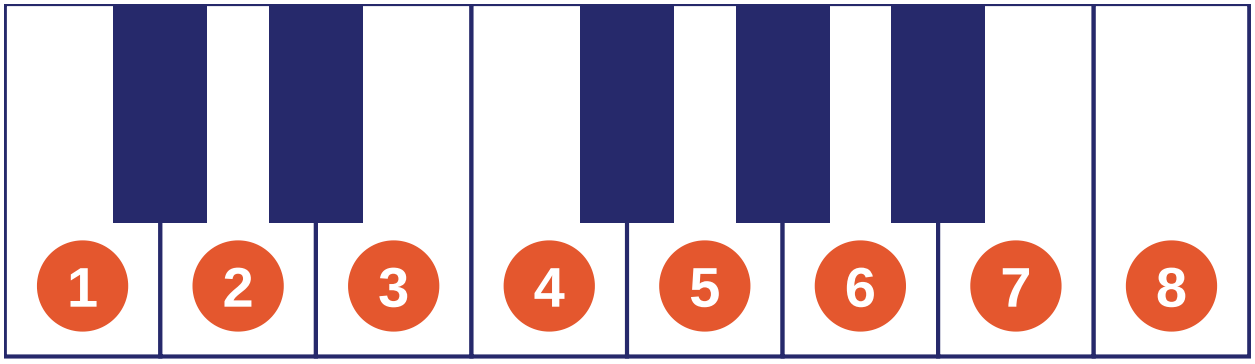
Try it at the piano

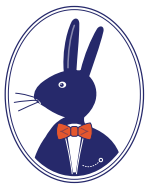
1 Play F, then F sharp. Then play G major and listen for the F sharp near the top.

ROOM 9 · STEP 1 OF 4

Major scales

SCAN TO LISTEN





A **scale** is a ladder of eight notes. Play the white keys from C to the next C and you have **C major**.

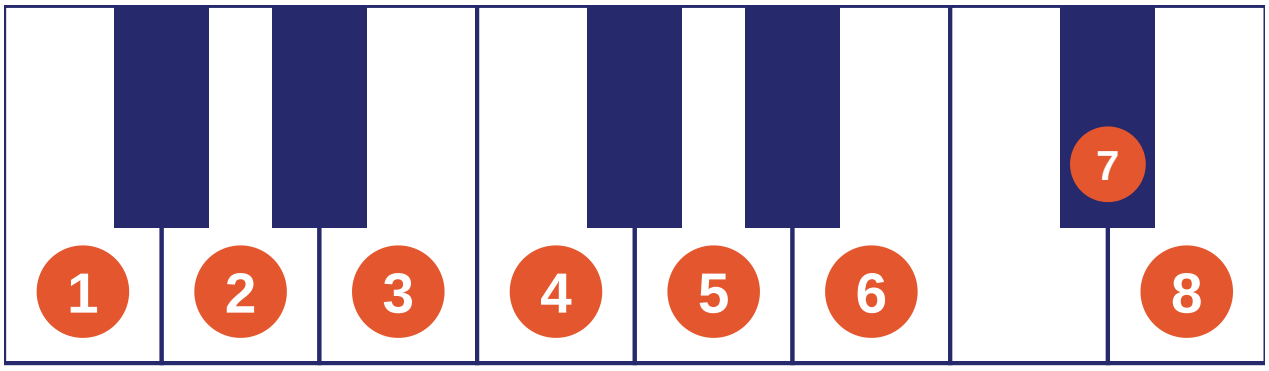
Notes **3–4** and **7–8** are close together, with no black key between. Every other pair has a black key between.

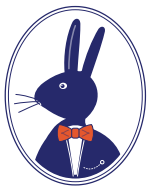
Try it at the piano

1 Play C major going up with one finger, saying the numbers 1 to 8. Listen for the two close steps. (Which fingers? That comes two pages on.)

ROOM 9 · STEP 2 OF 4

Major scales





G major starts the same ladder on G. One note has to change: the 7th becomes **F sharp**, so that 7–8 stay close.

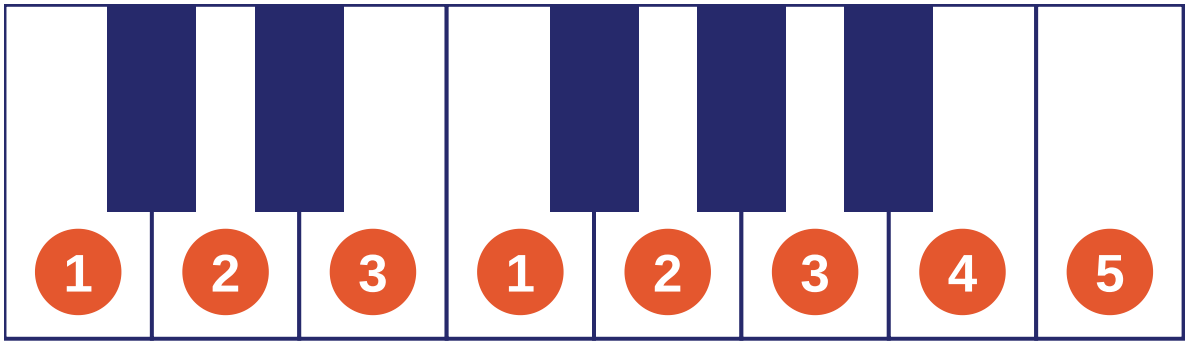
A **sharp** (♯) is the very next key to the right, here a black one. G major has one sharp, F♯.

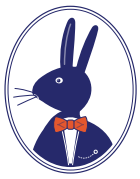
Try it at the piano

1. Play G A B C D E, then the black key F♯, then G. Now try it with a white F: hear how it sounds wrong.

ROOM 9 · STEP 3 OF 4

Major scales





Eight notes, five fingers. Going up, the right hand plays **1 2 3**, then the **thumb tucks under** and plays **1 2 3 4 5**.

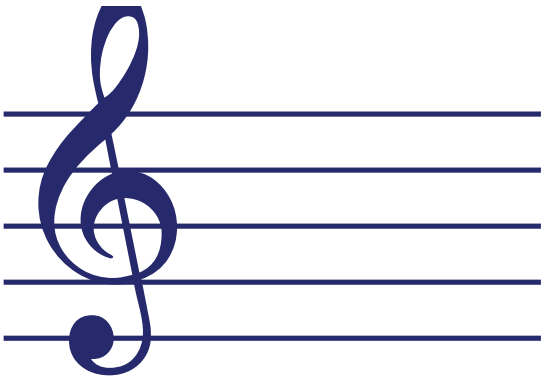
From one C to the next is one **octave**. Coming down, play 5 4 3 2 1, then finger 3 crosses over: 3 2 1. The same fingers work for G major, A minor and E minor.

Try it

1. Right hand, C major, one octave up and down, slowly. Say the finger numbers. Left hand going up: 5 4 3 2 1, then finger 3 crosses over: 3 2 1. ○

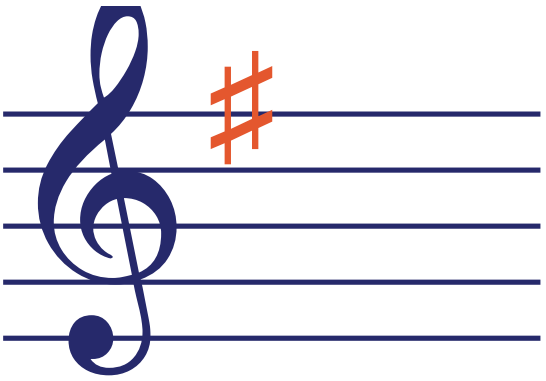
ROOM 9 · STEP 4 OF 4

Major scales



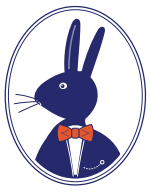
C major

no sharps



G major

one sharp: F♯



The sharps printed right after the clef are the **key signature**. They tell you which notes are sharp all the way through.

No sharps: C major. One sharp, on the F line: G major. Every F is then played as F♯.

Try it

1. Look at the start of your piece. How many sharps are after the clef?

ROOM 9 · HOW IT ENDED

Major scales

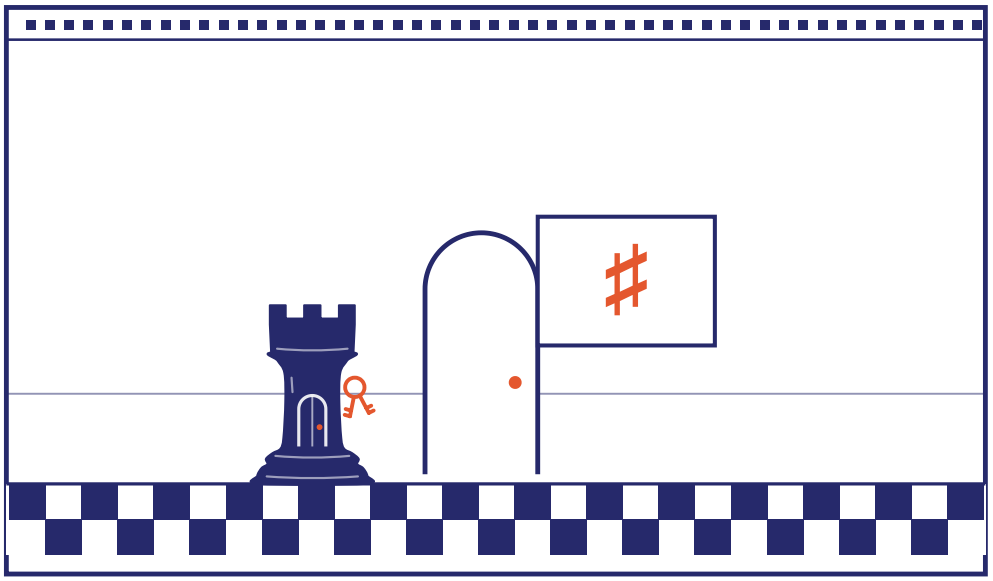


Plate IX. The Doorkeeper's list, which has one line on it.



So the Doorkeeper writes it on his list, once, at the start of every line of music: one sharp, on F.

That list is the **key signature**. It saves writing the hat on every single F.

The Guest is a little put out. In G major an F sharp is no surprise at all, so he must save his hat for notes that are not on the list.

Try it

1 Open a piece. Is there a list after the clef? How many sharps does it have?

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

The Doorkeeper had one more list, much older than the first. It belonged to the rooms at the far end of the house, where the curtains are always half drawn.

ROOM 10 · THE STORY

Minor scales

HEAR THE STORY

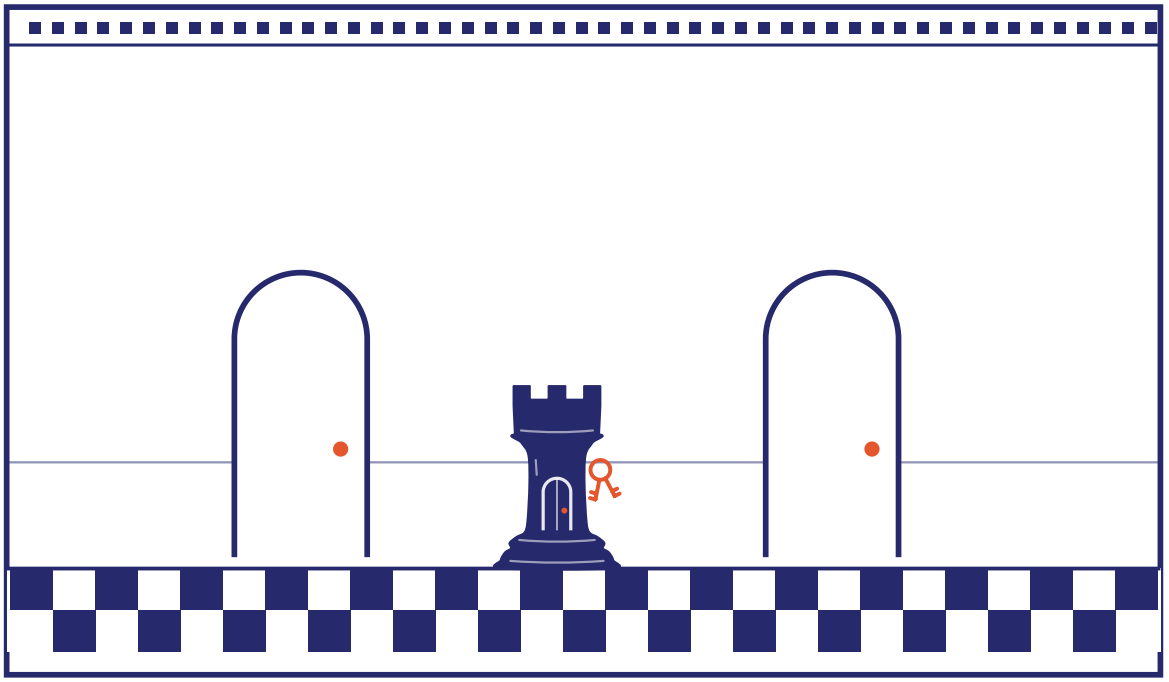
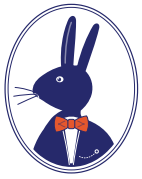


Plate X. The Doorkeeper, at the door of the darker rooms.



At the far end of the house there is a set of rooms with the curtains half drawn. They use the same white keys as C major, except that a guest in a sharp hat, G sharp, often calls on the way up. But here, **A** is home.

“Same furniture,” says the Doorkeeper. “Different light.”

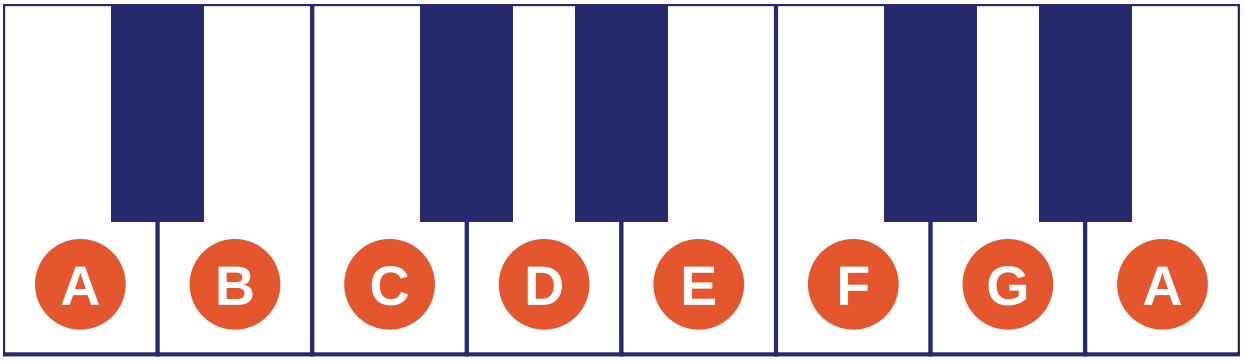
Try it at the piano

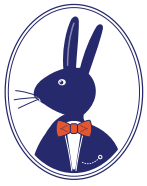
1. Play C major, then the white keys from A to A. What changes in the mood?

ROOM 10 · STEP 1 OF 3

Minor scales

SCAN TO LISTEN





Play the white keys from A to A and you have **A minor**. It uses the same notes as C major, so its key signature has no sharps. But A is home, and it sounds darker.

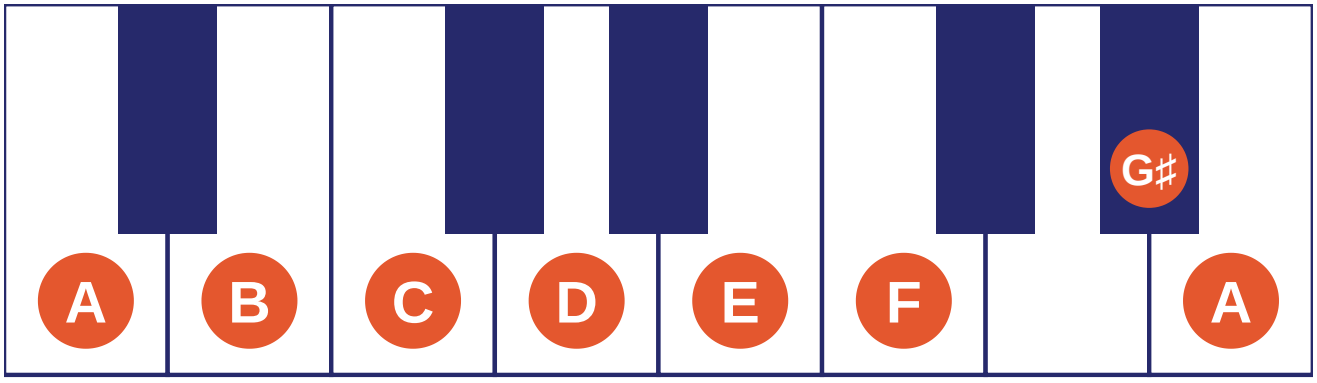
This plain form is the **natural minor**.

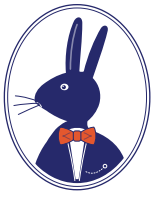
Try it at the piano

1. Play C major up and down, then A natural minor. Same white notes, a different mood.

ROOM 10 · STEP 2 OF 3

Minor scales





Raise the 7th note one key, G to **G sharp**, and the scale pulls strongly back home.

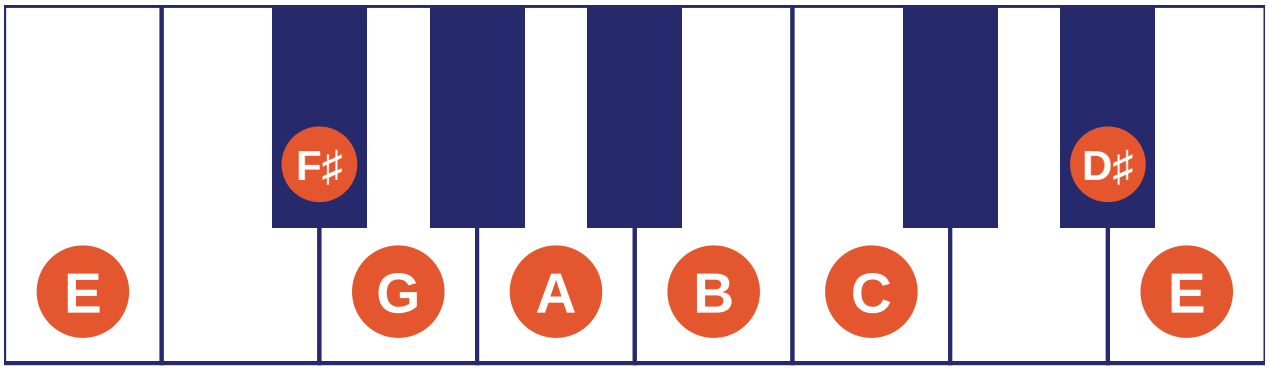
This is the **harmonic minor**: A B C D E F G♯ A.

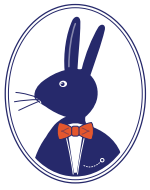
Try it at the piano

1. Play A harmonic minor slowly. Stop on G♯ and feel how much it wants to go up to A.

ROOM 10 · STEP 3 OF 3

Minor scales





E minor uses the same notes as G major, so it keeps **F sharp** and the same key signature. E is home.

For the harmonic minor, raise its 7th note too: D becomes **D sharp**.

Try it at the piano

1. Play E natural minor (with F♯), then E harmonic minor (F♯ and D♯).

ROOM 10 · HOW IT ENDED

Minor scales

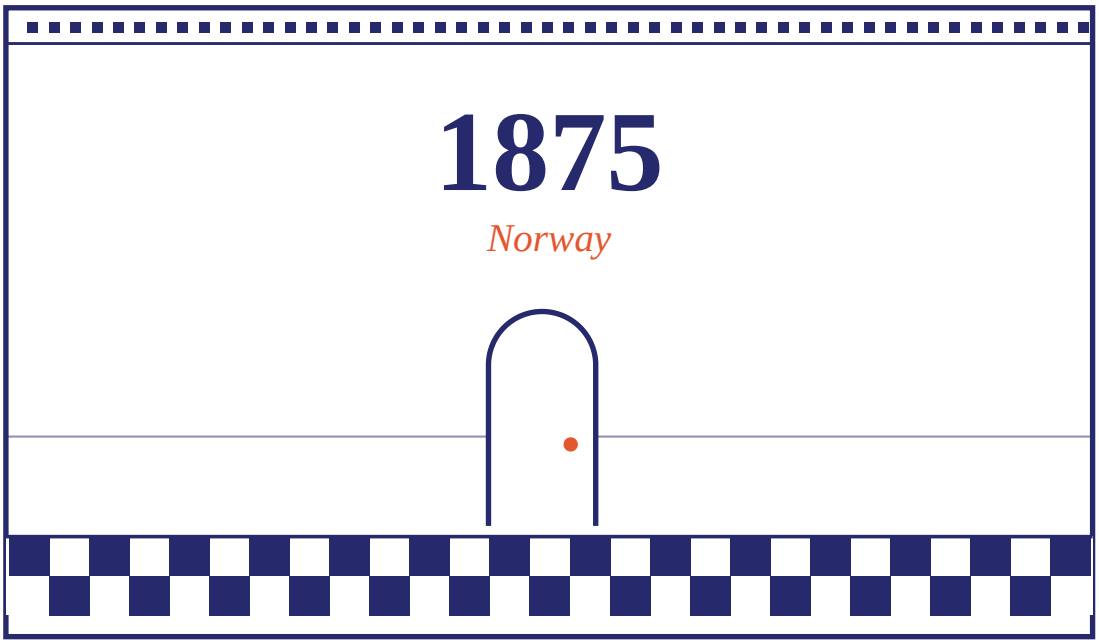


Plate X. The Hall of the Mountain King, in B minor.



In Norway, **Grieg** wrote music for a story about a hall deep inside a mountain, ruled by a troll king. It is called *In the Hall of the Mountain King*.

It is in B minor. It starts quietly, creeps closer, and gets faster and louder until the very end.

Try it at the piano

1. Play A minor up and down, slowly and softly. Then quicker and louder, as if the trolls were coming.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

From the darker rooms, three notes came floating out at once. Somehow they sounded like one.

ROOM 11 · THE STORY

Chords and triads

HEAR THE STORY

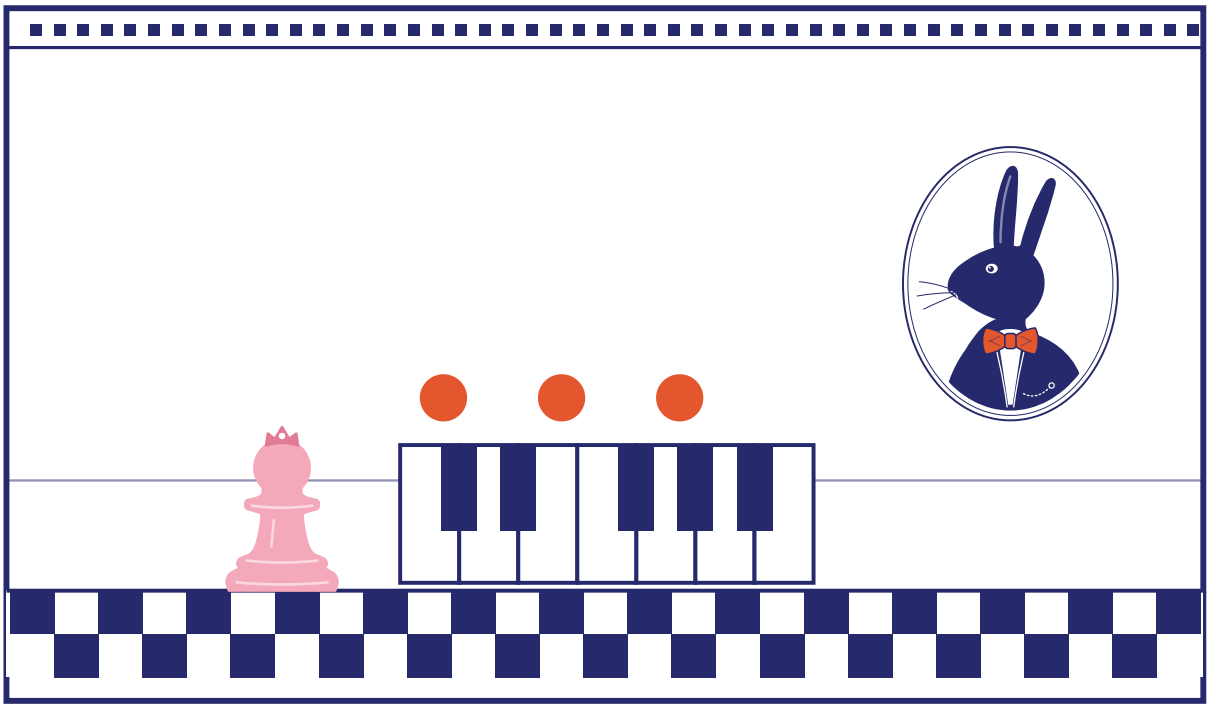
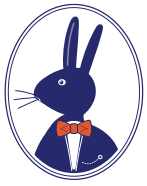


Plate XI. Three notes at once: play one, skip one.



The Butler places three of Clara's fingers on the keys: one, skip one, one, skip one, one. "Now," he says, "all together."

Three notes sound as one. It is the first **chord** Clara has ever played.

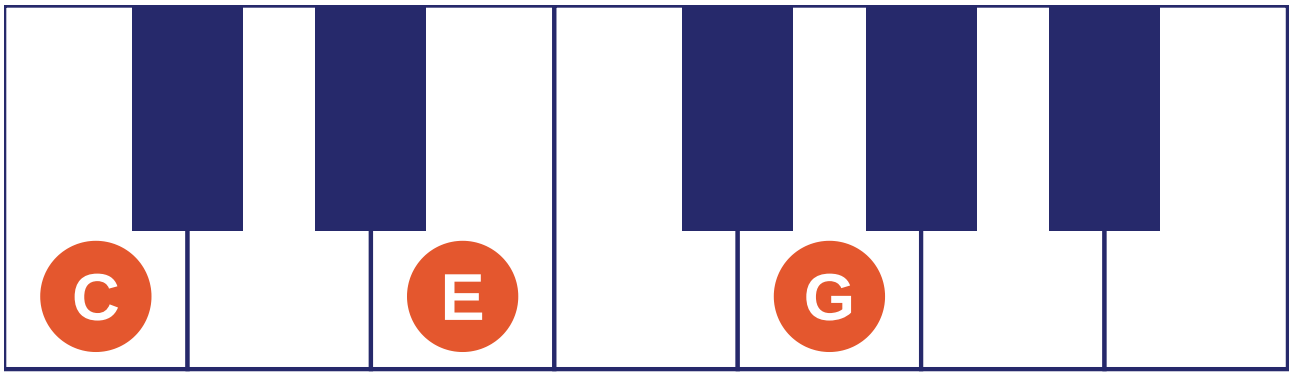
Try it at the piano

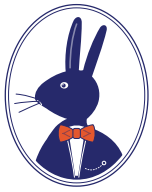
1. Play C, E and G one at a time. Then all three together. Which sounds fuller?

ROOM 11 · STEP 1 OF 2

Chords and triads

SCAN TO LISTEN





A **chord** is notes played together. The simplest full chord is a **triad**: three notes.

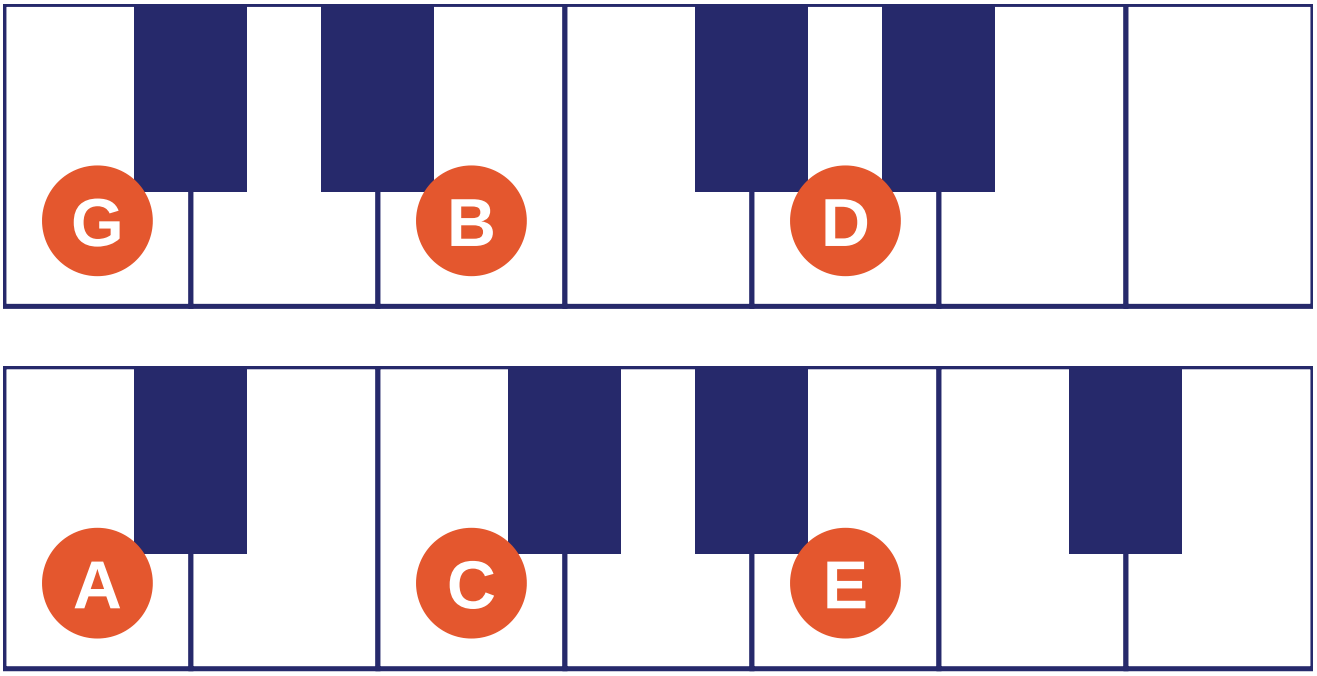
To build one: **play one, skip one, play one, skip one, play one**. C, E, G.

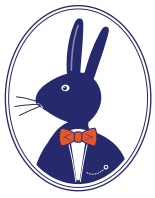
Try it at the piano

1 Right hand fingers 1, 3 and 5 on C, E and G. Play them one at a time, then all together.

ROOM 11 · STEP 2 OF 2

Chords and triads





The triad shape works on other white keys too. On G it gives **G B D**. On A it gives **A C E**.

The bottom note names the triad. C and G sound bright: **major**. A sounds darker: **minor**.

Try it

1. Keep your hand in the triad shape and move it: C E G, then G B D, then A C E. ○

ROOM 11 · HOW IT ENDED

Chords and triads

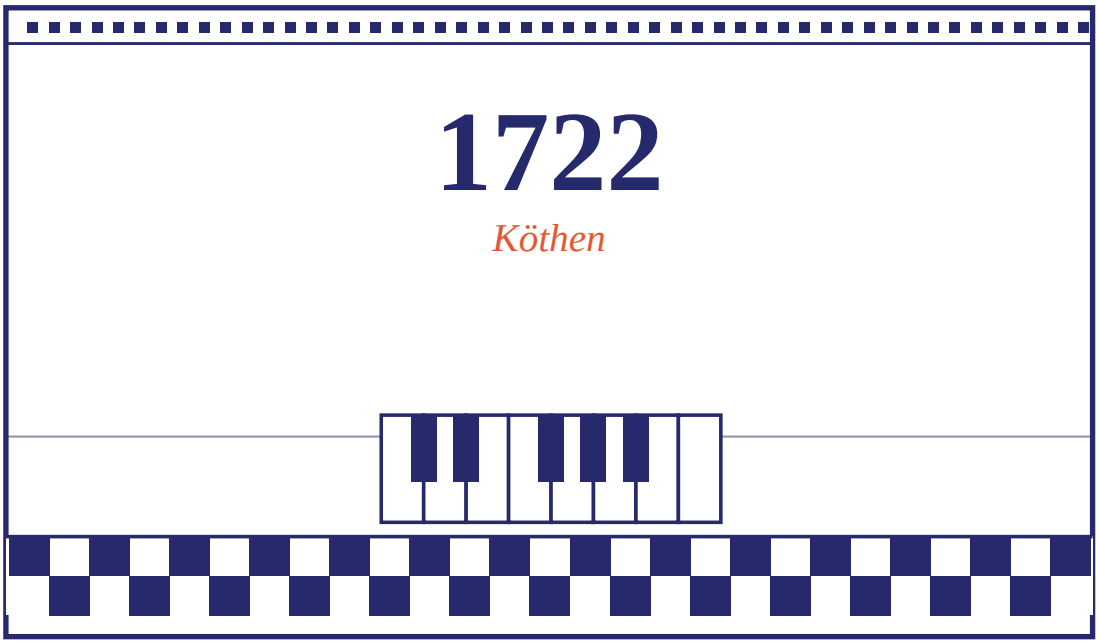


Plate XI. A prelude made of chords, one note at a time.



Johann Sebastian Bach wrote a famous prelude in C major almost entirely out of chords, played one note at a time, like these.

Musicians have played it for three hundred years. It begins with the very chord you just played.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C E G, one note at a time, going up. Then do the same with G B D and A C E.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

That night the house grew very quiet, and Clara found she could hear things she had never noticed before.

ROOM 12 · THE STORY

Ear training

HEAR THE STORY

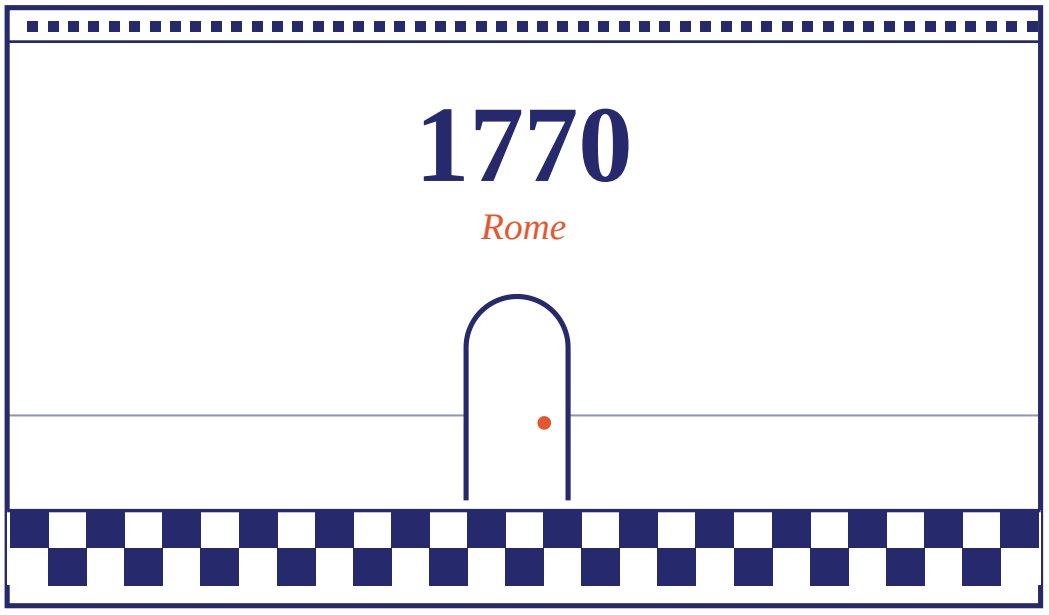


Plate XII. A boy of fourteen, listening very carefully.



The story goes that in Rome, the young **Mozart**, aged fourteen, heard Allegri's *Miserere* sung in the Pope's chapel, a long piece nobody was allowed to copy.

He went home and wrote the whole thing down from memory, then went back a second time to check.

Try it at the piano

1 Ask someone to play three notes. Sing them back. Then play them yourself to check.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

Upstairs, the next floor was waiting: GRADE 1. Behind its first door, something was humming, somewhere above the top line of the staff.

ROOM 12 · LISTEN

Ear training

SCAN TO PLAY

1

Clap the beat

2

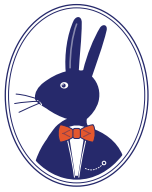
Echo the rhythm

3

Sing the tune

4

Higher or lower?



Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Four listening games belong to this level. Each one is in the app: scan the code and play one each day.

Try it at the piano

1 Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?